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London

For other places with the same name, see [London \(disambiguation\)](#).

Vibrant and truly multicultural, **London** is a megalopolis of people, ideas and frenetic energy. The capital and largest city of the [United Kingdom](#) sits on the River Thames in [South-East England](#). **Greater London** has a population of a little over 9 million. Considered one of the world's leading "global cities", London remains an international capital of culture, music, education, fashion, politics, finance and trade.

For the visitor, there is a seemingly endless choice of historical sites, shopping, museums, food, art galleries, nightlife, and activities. Once a Celtic settlement, London is a bustling city, where visitors come to experience the urban heritage and see its specific royal-themed attractions.



Historical Routemaster double-decker bus outside St Paul's cathedral 

Districts

The name "London" used to refer only to the once-walled "Square Mile" of the original Roman and later medieval city; this is now confusingly called the "[City of London](#)" or just "[The City](#)". Today, London has taken on a much larger meaning to include all of the vast central parts of the modern metropolis, with the city having absorbed numerous surrounding towns and villages over the centuries, including large portions of the surrounding "home counties", one of which - [Middlesex](#) - being completely consumed by the growing metropolis. The term [Greater London](#) embraces Central London together with all the outlying suburbs that lie in one continuous urban sprawl within the lower Thames Valley. Though densely populated, London retains large swathes of green parkland and open space, even within the city centre.

Greater London is most of the area surrounded by the M25 orbital motorway, and consists of 32 London Boroughs and the City of London that, together with the office of the Mayor of London, form the basis for London's local government. The Mayor of London is elected by London residents and should not be confused with the Lord Mayor of the City of London. The names of several boroughs, such as [Westminster](#) and [Camden](#), are well-known, others less so, such as [Wandsworth](#) and [Lewisham](#). This traveller's guide to London recognises cultural, functional and social districts of varying type and size:

Central London

Bloomsbury (*British Museum, Cartoon Museum, Foundling Museum, University College London, Wellcome Collection*)
Vibrant historic district made famous by a group of turn-of-the-century writers. It is now the location of numerous historic homes, and oasis-like squares fringed by elegant buildings.

City of London (*Bank of England, Museum of London, Tower Bridge, Tower of London, St Paul's Cathedral*)
The City is where London developed within the Roman city walls. It is a city in its own right, separate from the rest of London. It is now one of the most important financial centres in the world, and an area where modern skyscrapers stand next to medieval churches on ancient street layouts.

Covent Garden (*Covent Garden Piazza, London Transport Museum, Royal Opera House*)
One of the main shopping and entertainment districts, and part of London's West End Theatreland.

Holborn-Clerkenwell (*Hatton Garden, Inns of Court, Royal Courts of Justice, Sadler's Wells, Somerset House*)
Buffer zone between the West End and the City of London financial district, and the home of English Common Law.

Leicester Square (*National Gallery, National Portrait Gallery, Piccadilly Circus, Trafalgar Square*)
A West End district that is the centre of London's Theatreland, features UK and world cinema premieres and is also home to the city's Chinatown.

Mayfair-Marylebone (*London Zoo, Madame Tussauds, Regent's Park, Royal Academy of Arts, Wallace Collection*)
Some extremely well-heeled districts of west central London with London's primary shopping streets, among them Bond Street, Oxford Street, Regent Street and Savile Row.

Notting Hill-North Kensington (*Design Museum, Holland Park, Museum of Brands, Portobello Road Market*)
Lively fruit and antiques market, interesting history, the world famous carnival and a very ethnically diverse population

Paddington-Maida Vale (*Abbey Road, Little Venice, Lord's Cricket Ground*)
Largely residential district of northwest central London with lots of mid-range accommodation, famous for its canal and houseboats.

Soho (*Carnaby Street, Soho Square*)
Dense concentration of highly fashionable restaurants, cafés, clubs and jazz bars, as well as London's gay village all mixed in with a cluster of sex shops and sexual-themed venues.

South Bank (*Borough Market, British Film Institute, London Eye, National Theatre, Shakespeare's Globe Theatre, Tate Modern, The Shard*)
This district has many artistic and creative sites, and an eclectic range of other attractions, boutique shopping and trendy food and drink places.



Central London

South Kensington-Chelsea (*Kensington Palace, Kensington Gardens, Natural History Museum, Royal Albert Hall, Science Museum, Victoria and Albert Museum*)

An extremely well-heeled inner London district with famous department stores, Hyde Park, many museums and the King's Road.

Westminster (*Buckingham Palace, Downing Street, Horse Guards, Houses of Parliament, Tate Britain, Westminster Abbey, Westminster Cathedral*)

The seat of government and an almost endless list of historical and cultural sights. Relax in one of two beautiful Royal parks, Green Park and St James's Park

Inner London

Camden (*British Library, Camden Town Markets, Jewish Museum, King's Cross and St Pancras International stations*)

A diverse area of north London that includes eclectic Camden Town, a hub of alternative fashion and youth-oriented markets.

East End (*Brick Lane, Columbia Road Flower Market, Docklands, Petticoat Lane Market, Spitalfields Market, Young V&A*)

A traditional working class heartland of inner London to the east of The City, made famous by countless movies and TV shows. Once the stalking ground of Jack the Ripper, now home to hipster-y bars, art galleries and parks, and an extremely diverse population.

Greenwich (*London cable car, Maritime Greenwich, Prime Meridian, Royal Observatory, The O2 Arena*)

On the pretty southern banks of the Thames is an area with strong links to Britain's seafaring heritage and breathtaking views across to Canary Wharf.

Hackney (*Hackney Empire, London Fields, Museum of the Home, Victoria Park*)

Hackney has become fashionable and is home to a thriving arts scene as well as many trendy cafés, bars, and pubs.

Hammersmith and Fulham (*Chelsea FC, Fulham FC, Fulham Palace, Shepherd's Bush Empire, Westfield White City*)

Well-heeled Thames-side borough in west London which is a hotbed for professional football and diverse shopping experiences.

Hampstead (*Freud Museum, Highgate Cemetery, Keats House, Kenwood House, Primrose Hill*)

Literary north London and the wonderful open spaces of Hampstead Heath.

Islington (*Arsenal FC*)

Area to the north of Clerkenwell that has undergone huge gentrification since 1990.

Lambeth (*Imperial War Museum, Lambeth Palace, The Old Vic, The Oval Cricket Ground*)

A diverse multicultural district to the south of the River Thames; includes LGBT-friendly **Vauxhall**, more middle class **Clapham** and the Caribbean flavours of **Brixton**.

Southwark-Lewisham (*Crystal Palace Park, Dulwich Picture Gallery, Horniman Museum*)

Inner southern districts of London; traditionally residential, with a large melting pot of



Inner London

communities. The area retains some leftfield, quirky attractions. You can find a restaurant from just about any ethnic group in the world.

Wandsworth (*Battersea Park, Battersea Power Station, Clapham Common, London Wetland Centre*)

Grand Thames-side areas and open green parks to the north, and dense housing to the south.

Outer London

Richmond-Kew (*Bushy Park, Hampton Court Palace, National Archives, Richmond Park, Royal Botanic Gardens, Twickenham Stadium*)

Leafy Thames-side scenery with a semi-rural feel which is helped by the presence of major parkland and numerous large aristocratic residences.

Wimbledon (*All England Lawn Tennis and Croquet Club, New Wimbledon Theatre, Wimbledon Lawn Tennis Museum*)

Home to the annual tennis championships and wombling Wimbledon Common.

North (*Alexandra Palace, Highgate Wood, Neasden Temple, RAF Museum, Tottenham Hotspur FC, Wembley Stadium*)

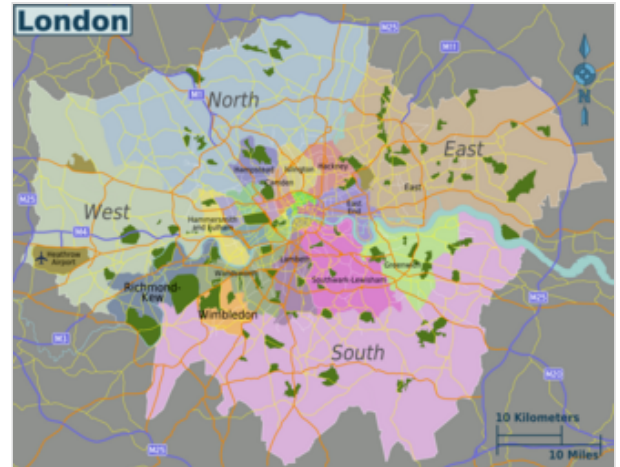
Largely made up of lush green middle-class suburbs.

South (*Chessington World of Adventures, Chislehurst Caves, Down House*)
Containing many commuter suburbs with housing in varying styles, as well as the buzzing urban centres of **Sutton**, **Kingston upon Thames**, **Croydon** and **Bromley**.

East (*City Airport, Queen Elizabeth Olympic Park, West Ham United FC, Westfield Stratford City*)

Includes former industrial areas on the upper Thames Estuary, while to the northeast lies the gateway to the affluent Epping Forest area.

West (*Chiswick House, Heathrow Airport, Musical Museum, Osterley Park, Syon Park*)
This suburban 'commuter belt' territory is a diverse area that ranges from the densely-populated but tree-lined streets, through to the semi-rural western districts.



Greater London map showing the Outer London districts.

Understand

“When a man is tired of London, he is tired of life; for there is in London all that life can afford

”

Samuel Johnson

History

Settlements have existed on the site of London since well before Roman times, with evidence of Bronze Age and Celtic inhabitants. The Roman city of *Londinium*, established just after the Roman conquest of Britannia in the year 43, formed the basis for the modern city (some isolated Roman period remains are still to be seen within the City). After the end of Roman rule in 410 and a short-lived decline, London experienced a gradual revival under the Anglo-Saxons, as well as the Norsemen, and emerged as a great medieval trading city, eventually replacing Winchester as the royal capital of England. This paramount status for London was confirmed when William the Conqueror, a Norman, built the Tower of London after the conquest in 1066 and was crowned King of England in Westminster.



The Tower of London



London went from strength to strength with the rise of England to first European then global prominence, and the city became a great centre of culture, government and industry. London's long association with the theatre, for example, can be traced back to the English Renaissance (witness the Rose Theatre (<https://www.rosetheatre.org/>) and great playwrights like Shakespeare who made London their home). With the rise of Britain to supreme maritime power in the 18th and 19th centuries (see Industrial Britain) and the possessor of the largest global empire, London became an imperial capital and drew people and influences from around the world to become, for many years, the largest city in the world.

England's royal family has, over the centuries, added much to the London scene for today's traveller: the Albert Memorial, Buckingham Palace, Kensington Palace, Royal Albert Hall, Tower of London, Kew Palace and Westminster Abbey being prominent examples.

Despite the decline of the British Empire, and suffering during the Second World War when London was heavily bombed by the German Luftwaffe in the Blitz, the city remains a top-tier world city: a global centre of culture, finance, and learning. London is easily the largest city in the United Kingdom, eight times larger than the second largest, Birmingham, and ten times larger than the third, Glasgow, and dominates the economic, political and social life of the nation. It's full of excellent bars, galleries, museums, parks and theatres. It is also the most culturally and ethnically diverse part of the country, and arguably of the whole of Europe as well, making it a great multicultural city to visit. Samuel Johnson famously said, "when a man is tired of London, he is tired of life". Whether you are interested in ancient history, modern art, opera or underground raves, London has it all.

The City and Westminster

Historically London was two cities: a commercial city and a separate government capital.

The commercial capital was the City of London. This had a dense population and all the other pre-requisites of a medieval city: walls, a castle (The Tower of London), a cathedral (St Paul's), a semi-independent City government, a port and a bridge across which all trade was routed so Londoners could make money (London Bridge).

About an hour upstream (on foot or by boat) around a bend in the river was the government capital (Westminster). This had a church for crowning the monarch (Westminster Abbey) and palaces. As each palace was replaced by a larger one, the previous one was used for government, first the Palace of Westminster (better known as the Houses of Parliament), then Whitehall, then Buckingham Palace. The two were linked by a road called The "Strand", the old English word for "riverbank".

London grew both west and east. The land to the west of the City (part of the parish of Westminster) was prime farming land (Covent Garden and Soho for example) and made good building land. The land to the east was flat, marshy and cheap, good for cheap housing and industry, and later for docks. Also the wind blows 3 days out of 4 from west to east, and the Thames (into which the sewage went) flows from west to east. So the West End was up-wind and up-market, the East End was where people worked for a living.

Modern-day London in these terms is a two-centre city, with the area in between known confusingly as the West End.

Climate

Despite having perhaps a fair reputation for being unsettled, London enjoys a mild climate on average. As much as one in three days on average will bring rain, though sometimes for only a short period. In some years, 2012 and 2018 being examples, there was no rain for a number of weeks. The fact that Londoners would find this remarkable should be an indication to visitors from drier climates of what they may be in for!

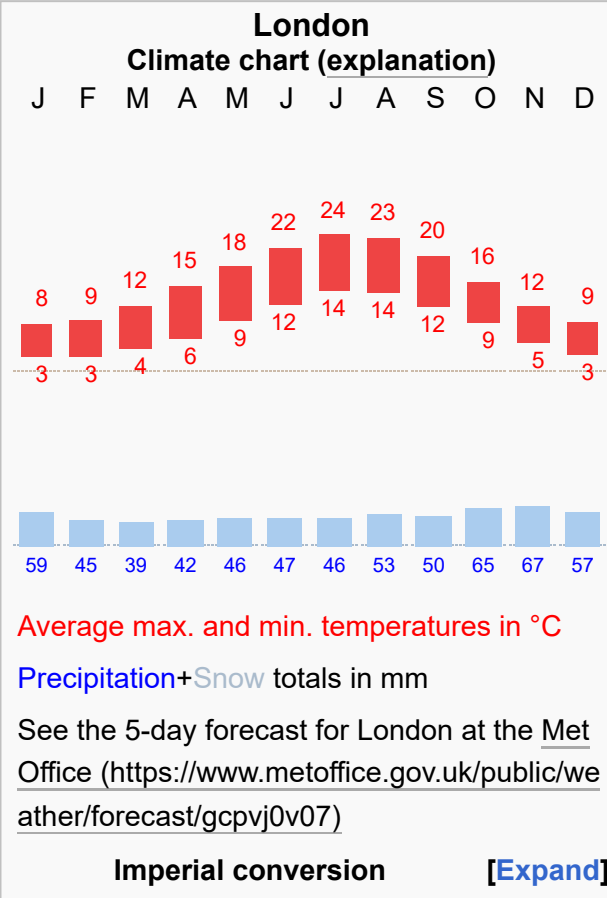
Extreme weather is rare. Occasionally there may be heavy rain that can bring localised flooding or strong winds that may down trees and damage roofs, but overall you are unlikely to encounter anything too lively.

Winter

Winter in London is mild compared to nearby continental European cities due to both the presence of the Gulf Stream and the urban heat effect. The average daily maximum temperature is



The Elizabeth Tower is the iconic tower that is home to the bell known as 'Big Ben'



8 °C (46 °F) in December and January. The coldest temperature recorded in London stands at −16.1 °C (3.0 °F) and was recorded at Northolt during January 1962, but this occurred during one of the coldest winters ever experienced in the UK.

Daylight hours are very short, especially around winter, with darkness falling at 3:45PM in the afternoon in December. Sunrise is not until after 8AM around the end of December.

Snow does occur, usually a few times a year but rarely heavily (a few years being exceptions such as the winters of 2009 and 2010, with temperatures dipping down to sub-zeros regularly). Snow in London can be crippling, as seen at the end of 2010. Just 7 centimetres (2 ¾ inches) of snow will cause trains to stop running, airports to see significant delays, and the postal service to come to a halt. London is a city which does not cope well with snow; walkways, stairs, and streets will not be cleared by shovels or ploughs. The streets will be salted/gritted, but will remain slick and snow/slush-covered until the sun melts it away. This is due to a lack of widespread snow-clearing infrastructure as the city does not often see snow.

Spring

Spring in the capital can be something of a weather rollercoaster with big variations in temperature day by day. It can be a very wet time of year, but the increases in day length from March onwards and steady temperature increases as the season progresses can make it a pleasant time to visit.

Days can be mild and warm, but the temperature will often dip at night as the sun's warmth dissipates.

The beginning of spring in March can be as cold as winter, so be sure to bring something warm to wear!

Summer

Summer is perhaps the best season for tourists, as it has long daylight hours as well as mild to warm temperatures. The average daily high temperatures in July and August are around 23.5 °C (74.3 °F) with average daily lows around 16 °C (61 °F). On particularly hot days, the temperature can climb up to around 29 °C (84 °F) and not go below 18.5 °C (65.3 °F) at night, but these aren't particularly common. The highest temperature ever seen in London stands at 40.2 °C (104.4 °F) which was recorded at Heathrow on 19 July 2022. Daylight hours run from 4:45AM to 9:15PM, but begin to shorten as the summer goes on.

Humidity across the city can increase and stay high over the course of several days and nights, leading to muggy conditions. Also, upon occasion, clouds of dust from storms in the Sahara desert can be blown across Europe and lead to increases in pollution levels.

Despite the increased warmth, the weather in summer can be variable. Occasional prolonged instances of rain and unexpected dips in temperature can occur. If you're coming during the summer it is still advised to dress in layers and bring some waterproofs!

Autumn

Autumn in London can vary from year to year: in some years September and October can see temperatures similar to those seen in summer due to a phenomenon known as an "Indian summer", but in other years the temperature can decrease rapidly to winter levels and stay there. Autumn tends to be the wettest and windiest season but, again, this can vary from year to year. Day length at the beginning of autumn is near that of summer, meaning that a September trip can still be as easy to plan as an August one as there's plenty of daylight to work with.



The view over the River Thames towards Westminster from the London Eye

Mid-autumn is a wonderful time to wander one of London's many tree-filled parks as the leaves fade from green to gold. Another benefit of a September trip is that children return to school at the beginning of the month, meaning that some tourist attractions are quieter.

Tourist information

- **Visit London** (<https://www.visitlondon.com/>). The city's tourism website. (updated Jan 2024 |)
- **City of London Information Centre** (<https://www.cityoflondon.gov.uk/things-to-do/city-information-centre>), St. Paul's Churchyard, EC4M 8BX (*next to St. Paul's Cathedral*), ☎ +44 20 7332-3456. M-Sa 9:30AM-5:30PM, Su 10AM-4PM. The only impartial, face-to-face source of tourist information in Central London. (updated Jan 2024 |)

There is no office for tourist information for the UK or for England. However, as of 2022, Transport for London maintains four small visitor centres at certain arrival points (see TfL website (<https://tfl.gov.uk/travel-information/visiting-london/getting-around-london/visitor-centres>)) which offer advice on key attractions, how to travel on the TfL network, buying tickets, etc.

- **Piccadilly Circus** (*Piccadilly Circus Tube station*). F Sa 9AM-4:30PM. (updated Aug 2022 |)
- **Victoria Station** (*opposite platform 8 at Victoria rail station*). Tu-Sa 9AM-4:30PM. (updated Aug 2022 |)
- **King's Cross & St Pancras International** (*Kings Cross & St Pancras Tube station*). Tu-Sa 9AM-4:30PM. (updated Aug 2022 |)
- **Liverpool Street** (*Liverpool Street Tube station*). Tu-Th 9AM-4:30PM. (updated Aug 2022 |)

Talk

English is the main language spoken in London. Accents, however, do vary from **Standard Southern English**, a middle class accent that pervades the south of England to **Multicultural London English** (MLE), which has developed among younger Londoners who grew up with its cultural diversity. MLE has a Cockney base, but incorporates noticeable influences from South Asia, Africa and the Caribbean, and is often regarded as the most representative accent of modern British society.

Many languages are spoken by first-generation immigrants in London. For example, Mandarin and Cantonese are commonly spoken in Chinatown and other neighbourhoods with many ethnic Chinese residents, and South Asian languages such as Hindi, Urdu, Punjabi and Bengali are spoken among the South Asian communities.

Get in

By plane

London receives more flights than any other city in the world. It is served by six airports (**LON** ^{IATA} for all airports):

- London Heathrow Airport (**LHR** ^{IATA})
- London Gatwick Airport (**LGW** ^{IATA})
- London Stansted Airport (**STN** ^{IATA})
- London Luton Airport (**LTN** ^{IATA})
- London City Airport (**LCY** ^{IATA})
- London Southend Airport (**SEN** ^{IATA})



Summary map of rail connections to London airports

There are direct public transport connections between all London airports and the city centre. The quickest travel option is usually by train, tube or coach. When planning your trip, leave plenty of time to get to your destination from the airport.

If you arrive into a London airport and must catch a connecting flight from another airport, leave plenty of time to travel through London. This can be quite time consuming and you may need to catch two or more trains.

London Heathrow

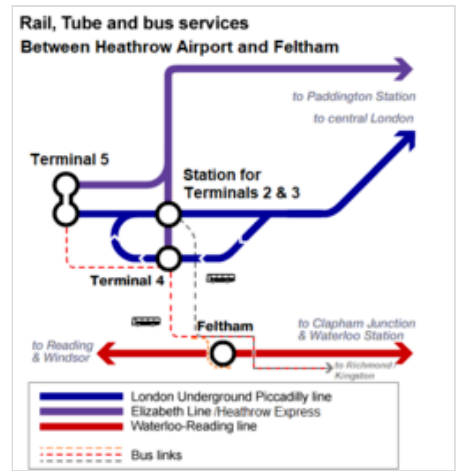
Main article: Heathrow Airport

1 London Heathrow Airport (<https://www.heathrow.com/>) (**LHR** ^{IATA}). Heathrow is Europe's busiest airport. There are four terminals numbered T2-T5. (updated Jan 2024 |)

There are several ways to get from London Heathrow Airport to central London:

- **Heathrow Express** (<https://www.heathrowexpress.com/>) - Non-stop trains to London Paddington. Departures every 15 minutes from Heathrow Terminal 2 and 3, and Heathrow Terminal 5. Journey time is 15-20 minutes.
- **ELI Elizabeth Line** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/elizabeth-line/>) - Stopping trains through London. Regular departures from all terminals. Journey time to Tottenham Court Road is approximately 35-40 minutes.
- **Piccadilly Line** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/tube/>) - London Underground "metro" trains through London. Regular departures from all terminals.
- **Coaches** - You can book a coach into London with Megabus (<https://uk.megabus.com/>) or National Express (<https://www.nationalexpress.com/en>). Most coaches arrive into London Victoria. Transfers to Gatwick, Luton and Stansted airports using National Express. You can also book a coach transfer to Gatwick Airport using The Airline (<https://www.theairlineoxford.co.uk/>).

- **Taxi** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/taxis-and-minicabs/taxi-fares>) - Taxi fares are regulated by Transport for London (TfL). Tariffs to central London from £64.
- **Pre-booked minicab** - Check with your preferred provider.
- **Car hire**- Several companies on-site. There are car hire desks in all terminals. Check [Heathrow Airport's website](https://www.heathrow.com/transport-and-directions/by-car/renting-a-car#/searchcars) (<https://www.heathrow.com/transport-and-directions/by-car/renting-a-car#/searchcars>) for details.
- The  connects Heathrow Airport with Hammersmith and central London. The  connects Heathrow Airport with areas of south, north and east London. If you are using a private car to travel to London City Airport, [Ultra Low Emission Zone](https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/driving/ultra-low-emission-zone) charges (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/driving/ultra-low-emission-zone>) may apply to a small number of vehicles.



Rail and Tube lines go to different terminals at Heathrow

London Gatwick

Main article: [Gatwick Airport](#)

2 London Gatwick Airport (<http://www.gatwickairport.com/>) (**LGW** ^{IATA}). London's second-busiest airport, [Gatwick](#) has two terminals - "North Terminal" and "South Terminal". You can fly into Gatwick from a large number of domestic and international destinations, particularly destinations in Europe. Airlines include British Airways (<https://www.britishairways.com/>), easyJet (<https://www.easyjet.com/en>), KLM (<https://www.klm.com/>), Ryanair (<https://www.ryanair.com/>) and TUI (<https://www.tui.co.uk/>). (updated Jan 2024 |)

There are several ways to get from London Gatwick Airport to London destinations:

- **Gatwick Express** (<https://www.gatwickexpress.com/>) - Non-stop trains to London Victoria. Departures every 15 minutes. Journey time is 30-35 minutes. You can pay for your journey using "touch in, touch out" Oyster and Contactless  payment cards. The Oyster and contactless fare is £24. Change at Victoria for London Underground    and other National Rail  services.
- **Southern** (<https://www.southernrailway.com/>) - Stopping trains towards East Croydon, Clapham Junction and London Victoria. Regular departures. Expect journey times around 40 minutes to central London. You can pay for your journey using "touch in, touch out" Oyster and Contactless  payment cards. Oyster and contactless fares to Zone 1 from £10.70 off-peak.
- **Thameslink** (<https://www.thameslinkrailway.com/>) - Stopping trains through London. Regular departures. Expect journey times around 40 minutes to central London. You can pay for your journey using "touch in, touch out" Oyster and Contactless  payment cards. Oyster and contactless fares to Zone 1 from £10.70 off-peak. Destinations include East Croydon, London Bridge, Farringdon (in The City), King's Cross St Pancras, Finsbury Park and Luton Airport .
- **Coaches** - You can book a coach transfer to London Victoria with several coach operators, including National Express (<https://www.nationalexpress.com/>). Transfers to Heathrow, Luton and Stansted airports using National Express. You can also book a coach transfer to Heathrow Airport using The Airline (<https://www.theairlineoxford.co.uk/>).
- **Pre-booked minicab** - Check with your preferred provider.
- **Car hire** - Several companies on-site. Check [Gatwick Airport's website](https://www.gatwickairport.com/premium-services/car-hire.html) (<https://www.gatwickairport.com/premium-services/car-hire.html>) for details. The  connects Gatwick Airport

with Croydon. Use  for south and central London destinations or  for other outer London areas.

London Stansted

Main article: [London Stansted Airport](#)

3 London Stansted Airport (<https://www.stanstedairport.com/>) (STN^{IATA}). Stansted is busy with short-haul flights from destinations in Europe, the Middle East and North Africa, as well as UK destinations including [Newquay](#), [Edinburgh](#) and [Belfast](#). Airlines include [easyJet](https://www.easyjet.com/) (<https://www.easyjet.com/>), [Jet2](https://www.jet2.com/) (<https://www.jet2.com/>) and [Ryanair](https://www.ryanair.com/) (<https://www.ryanair.com/>). (updated Jan 2024 |)



The terminal at Stansted Airport

As of March 2026, it is possible to touch-in and touch-out with contactless payment cards, but still not Oyster cards, to travel between Stansted and London by train. Buying a separate ticket will still be cheaper if you have any discount cards. There are several ways to get from London Stansted Airport to London destinations:

- **Stansted Express (<https://www.stanstedexpress.com/>)** - Fast trains to Tottenham Hale and London Liverpool Street. Departures every 15 minutes. Journey time is around 50 minutes. Change at Tottenham Hale for London Underground . Change at Liverpool Street for London Underground     and other National Rail  services.
- **Coaches** - There are several coaches, such as **Flibco (<https://www.flibco.com/en/shuttle/bus-coach-london-stansted-airport>)** and National Express (<https://www.nationalexpress.com/>) routes into destinations in London, including Bow, Finchley Road, Golders Green, Marble Arch, Paddington, Stratford and Waterloo. You can also use a direct shuttle [Airport Bus Express](https://www.airportbusexpress.co.uk/) (<https://www.airportbusexpress.co.uk/>) to Stratford and Liverpool Street. **Flibco (<https://www.flibco.com/en/shuttle/bus-coach-london-stansted-airport>)** operates a direct shuttle service from London Stansted Airport to Redbridge Station, Stratford, Liverpool Street Station, Finsbury Park, Wood Green and Enfield, with easy connections to central and North London. Buses are modern, equipped with Wi-Fi, and run frequently throughout the day.
- **Essex Airlink X30 (<https://www.firstbus.co.uk/essex/airlink>)** - Bus to London Southend Airport.
- **Pre-booked minicab** - Check with your preferred provider.
- **Car hire (<https://www.stanstedairport.com/at-the-airport/car-rental/>)** - Several companies on-site in the Car Rental Village. Check Stansted Airport's website (<https://www.stanstedairport.com/at-the-airport/car-rental/>) for details. The  connects Stansted Airport with east and central London. Use  for areas of north, west and south London.

London Luton

4 London Luton Airport (<https://www.london-luton.co.uk/>) (LTN^{IATA}). Luton Airport is around 30 miles from the capital. You can fly into Luton from a large number of European destinations, particularly smaller cities in southern and eastern Europe. Airlines include [easyJet](https://www.easyjet.com/en) (<https://www.easyjet.com/en>), [Ryanair](https://www.ryanair.com/) (<https://www.ryanair.com/>) and [Wizz Air](https://wizzair.com/) (<https://wizzair.com/>) (updated Jan 2024 |)

There are several ways to get from London Luton Airport to London destinations:

- **Luton Airport Express** (<https://www.lutonairportexpress.co.uk/>) - Non-stop trains to London St Pancras International, operated by East Midlands Railway (<https://www.eastmidlandsrailway.co.uk/>). Departures every 30 minutes from Luton Airport Parkway. Journey time is 32 minutes. You can pay for your journey using "touch in, touch out" Oyster and Contactless payment cards. Change at St Pancras for London Underground , other National Rail  services and Eurostar services to mainland Europe. To get to Luton Airport Parkway from the terminal, you can use the Luton DART (Direct Air-Rail Transit) (<https://www.lutondart.com/>) 24/7, with departures every 7 minutes during the daytimes.
- **Thameslink** (<https://www.thameslinkrailway.com/>) - Stopping trains through London. Regular departures from Luton Airport Parkway including overnight services. Expect journey times around 45 minutes to central London. You can pay for your journey using "touch in, touch out" Oyster and Contactless payment cards. Destinations include Brent Cross West, King's Cross St Pancras, Farringdon (in The City), London Bridge, East Croydon and Gatwick Airport ✈️. To get to Luton Airport Parkway from the terminal, you can use the Luton DART (Direct Air-Rail Transit) (<https://www.lutondart.com/>) 24/7, with departures every 7 minutes during the daytimes.
- **Coaches** - National Express (<https://www.nationalexpress.com/>) operates coaches into Golders Green, Finchley Road, Baker Street, Paddington, and Victoria. Green Line 757 (<https://www.arrivabus.co.uk/greenline/green-line-route-757>) operates coaches into Brent Cross, Finchley Road and Victoria with cheaper fares than most other operators
- **Pre-booked minicab** - Check with your preferred provider.
- **Car hire** - Several companies on-site. Check Luton Airport's website (<https://www.london-luton.co.uk/to-and-from-lla/need-to-hire-a-car>) for details. The  connects Luton Airport with Brent Cross and central London. Use  for areas of west, south and east London.

London City

5 **London City Airport** (<http://www.londoncityairport.com/>) (**LCY** ^{IATA}). Just 3.5 mi (5.6 km) from Canary Wharf, this "commuter" airport has short-haul flights from other major European cities. Also some holiday routes. British Airways (<https://www.britishairways.com/>) and Lufthansa (<https://www.lufthansa.com/>) are among the airlines which fly into London City Airport. (updated Jan 2024 |).



London City Airport

Plane tickets at London City tend to be more expensive than at other airports. London City Airport lies in east London. Onward travel is via:

- **DLR Docklands Light Railway** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/dlr/>) - London City Airport has its own station in London fare zone 3. There are direct trains to Woolwich Arsenal, Canning Town, Stratford and Bank. Change at Poplar for DLR services to Canary Wharf and Greenwich. You can pay for your journey using "touch in, touch out" Oyster and Contactless payment cards.
- **Local buses** - Route 473 to Stratford and 474 to Canning Town and Manor Park. You can plan a journey using the Transport for London website (<https://tfl.gov.uk/plan-a-journey/>) or apps like Google Maps (<https://www.google.com/maps>) and Citymapper (<https://citymapper.com/>).
- **Taxi** - Fares vary.
- **Pre-booked minicab** - Check with your preferred provider.

- **Car hire** - Car hire firms near London City Airport include Avis (<https://www.avis.co.uk/drive-a-vis/car-hire-locations/europe/united-kingdom/england/london/london-city-airport>), Europcar (<https://www.europcar.co.uk/en-gb/stations/united-kingdom/london-city-airport>) and Hertz (<https://www.hertz.co.uk/p/car-hire/uk/london/london-city-airport>). After leaving London City Airport, follow **A1020** then **A13** for Canary Wharf and The City (westbound) or for the **M25** (eastbound). Follow **A1020** then **A406** North Circular Road for destinations in east, north and west London. Use Woolwich Ferry then **A205** for destinations in south London.
- If you are using a private car to travel to London City Airport, Ultra Low Emission Zone charges (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/driving/ultra-low-emission-zone>) may apply to a small number of vehicles.

London Southend

6 London Southend Airport (<http://www.southendairport.com/>) (**SEN**^{IATA}). There are flights from a limited number of European destinations including Paris and Amsterdam. EasyJet (<https://www.easyjet.com/>) operates most flights into London Southend Airport. (updated Jan 2024 |)

Journeys into central London can take more than an hour. There is a railway station at Southend Airport, but you cannot use "touch in, touch out" Oyster and Contactless cards to travel between Southend and London. There are limited bus links with London. Options for travel into London include:

- **Greater Anglia** (<https://www.greateranglia.co.uk/>) - Stopping trains into London Liverpool Street and London Stratford. Regular departures. Expect journey times around 55 minutes to central London. Change at Stratford for London Underground **CEN** **JUB**, **DLR** and other National Rail  services. Change at Liverpool Street for London Underground **CEN** **CIR** **H&C** **MET** and other National Rail  services.
- **Essex Airlink X30** (<https://www.firstbus.co.uk/essex/airlink>) - Bus to London Stansted Airport.

By train

Wikivoyage has a guide to Rail travel in Great Britain

London is a major destination on the British rail network and every major city has a regular connection with the capital.

By National Rail

Prices vary depending on ticket type. These include:

- **Anytime** - travel at any time of day. Return tickets may usually be used within one month of your outbound journey. This is the most expensive ticket type and can be well in excess of £200 for some journeys.
- **Off-peak** - travel at off-peak times only. As a rule of thumb, you cannot travel on trains arriving into London between 6.30am and 10am on weekdays, or trains departing London between 4pm and 7pm on weekdays - although times vary by operator. Be sure to check with the retailer before you travel.
- **Super off-peak** - travel at the very quietest times of day. Super off-peak times vary by operator. Be sure to check with the retailer before you travel.

- **Advance** - travel on a specific service. You may only travel on your booked train. This is generally the cheapest ticket type, with prices cheaper the further in advance you book.

National Rail () is the umbrella brand for the rail network in Great Britain. It does not include London Underground (), Tramlink or DLR (), but some vendors sell London Travelcards which are valid for travel across the Transport for London networks. Some through tickets are also valid on London services.

You can buy tickets at ticket offices, via individual train companies or online:

-  **National Rail Enquiries** - <https://www.nationalrail.co.uk/> or by phone ☎ +44 345 748 4950
- **Trainline** - <https://www.thetrainline.com/>
- **Trainsplit** - It can be cheaper to buy lots of tickets for different portions of your route. Trainsplit finds the best value fares at <https://trainsplit.com/>

You may not have to buy a ticket from destinations within London's sphere of influence. Instead, you may be able to "touch in, touch out" using an Oyster or Contactless  payment card, on yellow-coloured readers at ticket gates or station entrances. Destinations within the Oyster and Contactless area include Amersham, Dartford, Gatwick Airport (), Heathrow Airport (), Hertford, Redhill and Watford (including Warner Bros Studio Tour London). Destinations within the Contactless area include St Albans, Hatfield, Reading, Slough and Welwyn Garden City.

Holidaymakers travelling between London and destinations further afield might be able to use a ranger or rover ticket. These include:

- **Interrail Global Pass** - Various conditions depending on pass type. Valid for travel across Europe. Seat reservation fees apply on Eurostar services from mainland Europe. Book online: <https://www.interrail.eu/>. Visitors from outside of Europe can use Eurail passes instead, also with online booking: <https://www.eurail.com/>.
- **Interrail One Country Pass (Great Britain)** - Various conditions and not available to Great Britain residents. Book online: <https://www.interrail.eu/en/interrail-passes/one-country-pass/great-britain>.
- **BritRail** - Hop-on, hop-off trains throughout Great Britain, England or the South East. Various conditions depending on pass type. BritRail Spirit of Scotland Pass must not be used in the London area. Passes do not include travel on London Underground, other Transport for London services or Eurostar services from mainland Europe. Book online: <https://www.britrail.com/>
- **Great West Way** - Conditions apply. Costs up to £285.50 for seven days. Valid on Great Western Railway between London Paddington and Windsor and Eton Central, Reading, Westbury, Bath and Bristol, and on South Western Railway between London Waterloo and Salisbury. More information: <https://www.gwr.com/your-tickets/choosing-your-ticket/rangers-and-rovers>
- **Thames Branches Day Ranger** - Conditions apply. Costs £26 for adults. Valid for one day on Great Western Railway routes between London Paddington and Reading, plus branch lines including routes to Windsor and Eton Central and Henley-on-Thames. More information: <https://www.gwr.com/your-tickets/choosing-your-ticket/rangers-and-rovers>.
- **Thames Rover** - Conditions apply. Seven-day pass costs £115.50. Three-day pass costs £64. Valid on Great Western Railway routes between London Paddington and the Cotswolds, Oxford, Banbury and Bedwyn, and also between Reading and Redhill via Guildford. More information: <https://www.gwr.com/your-tickets/choosing-your-ticket/rangers-and-rovers>.

By Eurostar

Travel direct into **London St Pancras International** (**QQS**^{IATA}) from:

- Lille-Europe  (around 1 hr 22 min)
- Paris Nord  (around 2 hr 15 min)
- Bruxelles-Midi/Brussel-Zuid  (around 1 hr 55 min)
- Rotterdam Centraal  (around 3 hr 15 min)
- Amsterdam Centraal  (around 4 hr)

High-speed trains pass beneath the English Channel in a 31.5 mi (50.7 km) tunnel between Calais, Hauts-de-France and Folkestone, Kent.

Book in advance for the cheapest fares (at <https://www.eurostar.com/>). Passengers using an Interrail or Eurail ticket will need to book a seat (<https://www.eurostar.com/uk-en/deals/interrail>) at an additional cost.

You may be able to combine your Eurostar journey with connections from other cities in Europe. Find tickets with third-party websites such as Trainline (<https://www.thetrainline.com/>) and Deutsche Bahn (<https://www.international-bahn.de/>).

Passengers with standard or standard premier tickets should arrive around **90 min** before their departure time (up to **120 min** at Paris Nord or **60 min** at Lille-Europe). You will need a passport for cross-channel travel, and will need to have your luggage checked at the station, before you get on the train. Gates close **30 min** before departure.

Eurostar trains boast an on-board café serving sandwiches, hot food, and hot and cold drinks. There are also food and drink outlets in the departure lounges, in most cases both before and after passport checks.

London St Pancras International is close to Camden Town - famous for its markets, pubs and music scene - and Bloomsbury - which is home to the British Museum, several universities, and independent bookshops and cafés.

London terminals

There are several major National Rail () stations in London. Clockwise from Paddington, these are:

- **7 London Paddington** (<https://www.networkrail.co.uk/communities/passengers/our-stations/london-paddington/>), in Paddington. *Services:*
 - **Great Western Railway** (<https://www.gwr.com/>) from the South West and South Wales, including Cornwall, Devon, Bristol, Bath, Cardiff, Swansea and Oxford. Change at Maidenhead from Windsor and Eton Central. Also Night Riviera overnight trains from Cornwall and Devon.
 - **Heathrow Express** (<https://www.heathrowexpress.com/>) from Heathrow Airport (✈).
 - **Elizabeth Line** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/>) from Reading, Maidenhead, Heathrow Airport (✈), Ealing, the City, Canary Wharf and Essex.
 - **Connections at London Paddington are:**      (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **8 London Marylebone** (http://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations_destinations/MYB.aspx), in Marylebone. *Services:*

- **Chiltern Railways** (<https://www.chilternrailways.co.uk/>) from the Chiltern Hills and the West Midlands, including Wembley Stadium, Bicester Village designer outlet, Oxford, Warwick and Birmingham Moor Street.
- **Connections at London Marylebone are:**  and      from Baker Street. (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **9 London Euston** (http://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations_destinations/EUS.aspx), near Camden. *Services:*
 - **Avanti West Coast** (<https://www.avantiwestcoast.co.uk/>) from the West Midlands, the North East, North Wales and Scotland, including Watford, Birmingham Airport (✈), Birmingham New Street, Manchester, Liverpool Llandudno Junction, Holyhead with ferries from  Ireland and  Northern Ireland (⚓), Oxenholme Lake District and Glasgow.
 - **London Northwestern Railway** (<https://www.londonnorthwesternrailway.co.uk/>) from the West Midlands and the North East, including Watford, Milton Keynes, Birmingham New Street and Liverpool.
 - **Caledonian Sleeper** (<https://www.sleeper.scot/>) overnight trains from Scotland, including Glasgow, Edinburgh, Fort William, Inverness, Aberdeen and destinations in the Scottish Highlands.
 - **London Overground** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/>) from Wembley Central and Watford.
 - **Connections at London Euston are:**    and    from nearby Euston Square. (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **10 London St Pancras International** (<http://stpancras.com/>) (**QQS**^{IATA}), near Camden. *Services:*
 - **Eurostar** (<https://www.eurostar.com/>) international trains from  France,  Belgium and  Netherlands including Paris Nord, Bruxelles-Midi/Brussel-Zuid and Amsterdam Centraal.
 - **East Midlands Railway** (<https://www.eastmidlandsrailway.co.uk/>) from the East Midlands and South Yorkshire including Leicester, Nottingham, Derby and Sheffield. Also **Luton Airport Express** (<https://www.lutonairportexpress.co.uk/>) direct to Luton Airport (✈). Change at Luton Airport Parkway for Luton DART (<https://www.lutondart.co.uk/>) to the terminal.
 - **Southeastern** (<https://www.southeasternrailway.co.uk/>) high-speed trains from Kent including Ashford, Canterbury and Dover.
 - **Thameslink** (<https://www.thameslinkrailway.com/>) from the South East and the East of England, including St Albans, Luton Airport (✈), Hatfield, Cambridge, Peterborough, Gatwick Airport (✈) and Brighton.
 - **Connections at London St Pancras International are:**       and National Rail (🚉) services from London King's Cross, which is within two minutes' walk. (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **11 London King's Cross** (http://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations_destinations/KGX.aspx), near Camden. *Services:*
 - **Grand Central** (<https://www.grandcentralrail.com/>) from Yorkshire and the North East including Halifax, Bradford, York and Sunderland.
 - **Hull Trains** (<https://www.hulltrains.co.uk/>) from Hull.
 - **LNER** (<https://www.lner.co.uk/>) from the North East and Scotland including Peterborough, Lincoln, Leeds, York, Newcastle upon Tyne, Edinburgh, Inverness and Dundee and Aberdeen.
 - **Lumo** (<https://www.lumo.co.uk/>) from the North East and Scotland, including Newcastle upon Tyne and Edinburgh.
 - **Great Northern** (<https://www.greatnorthernrail.com/>) and **Thameslink** (<https://www.thameslinkrailway.com/>) from the East of England including Hatfield, Stevenage,

Peterborough, Cambridge, Ely and the Norfolk Coast at King's Lynn.

- **Connections at London King's Cross are:**       and National Rail () services from London St Pancras International, which is within two minutes' walk. (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **12 London Moorgate (<https://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations/moorgate/>),** in the City of London. *Services:*
 - **Great Northern (<https://www.greatnorthernrail.com/>)** from Hertford, Hatfield and Stevenage.
 - **Elizabeth Line (<https://tfl.gov.uk/>)** (alight at Liverpool Street) from Reading, Heathrow Airport (✈), London Paddington, Canary Wharf and Essex.
 - **Connections at London Moorgate are:**      (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **13 London Liverpool Street (http://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations_destinations/LST.aspx),** in the City of London. *Services:*
 - **Greater Anglia (<https://www.greateranglia.co.uk/>)** from the East of England including Hertford, Cambridge, Colchester, Southend-on-Sea, Southend Airport (✈), Harwich with ferries from  Netherlands (⚓), and Norwich. Also **Stansted Express (<https://www.stanstedexpress.com/>)** from London Stansted Airport (✈).
 - **c2c (<https://www.c2c-online.co.uk/>)** from South Essex including Southend-on-Sea.
 - **Elizabeth Line (<https://tfl.gov.uk/>)** from Reading, Heathrow Airport (✈), London Paddington, Canary Wharf and Essex.
 - **London Overground (<https://tfl.gov.uk/>)** from North London, North East London and Hertfordshire.
 - **Connections at London Liverpool Street are:**       (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **14 London Fenchurch Street (http://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations_destinations/FST.aspx),** in the City of London. *Services:*
 - **c2c (<https://www.c2c-online.co.uk/>)** from South Essex including Southend-on-Sea.
 - **Connections at London Fenchurch Street are:**   from Tower Hill and  from Tower Gateway. (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **15 London Bridge (<https://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations/london-bridge/>),** near the South Bank. *Services:*
 - **Southeastern (<https://www.southeasternrailway.co.uk/>)** from Kent and East Sussex including Gravesend, Ashford and Hastings.
 - **Southern (<https://www.southernrailway.com/>)** from the South East including Epsom and East Grinstead.
 - **Thameslink (<https://www.thameslinkrailway.com/>)** from the South East and East of England including Gatwick Airport (✈), Brighton, St Albans, Luton Airport (✈), Cambridge and Peterborough.
 - **Connections at London Bridge are:**   (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **16 London Cannon Street (<https://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations/london-cannon-street/>),** in the City of London. *Services:*
 - **Southeastern (<https://www.southeasternrailway.co.uk/>)** from Kent and East Sussex including Gravesend, Ashford and Hastings.
 - **Connections at London Cannon Street are:**   (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **17 London Blackfriars (http://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations_destinations/BFR.aspx),** in the City of London and on the South Bank. *Services:*
 - **Southeastern (<https://www.southeasternrailway.co.uk/>)** from destinations within London.

- **Thameslink** (<https://www.thameslinkrailway.com/>) from the South East and East of England including Gatwick Airport (✈), Brighton, St Albans, Luton Airport (✈), Cambridge and Peterborough.
- **Connections at London Blackfriars** are: **CIR** **DIS** (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **18 London Charing Cross** (<https://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations/london-charing-cross/>), next to Trafalgar Square and the South Bank (via bridge). *Services:*
 - **Southeastern** (<https://www.southeasternrailway.co.uk/>) from Kent and East Sussex including Ashford, Canterbury, Ramsgate and Hastings.
 - **Connections at London Charing Cross** are: **BAK** **NOR** and **BAK** **CIR** **DIS** **NOR** from nearby Embankment. (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **19 London Waterloo** (http://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations_destinations/WAT.aspx), South Bank. *Services:*
 - **South Western Railway** (<https://www.southwesternrailway.com/>) from the South East and the South West including Windsor and Eton Riverside, Guildford, Southampton, Southampton Airport (✈), Bournemouth, Weymouth, Salisbury and Exeter.
 - **Connections at London Waterloo** are: **BAK** **JUB** **NOR** **W&C** (updated Aug 2024 |)
- **20 London Victoria** (http://www.nationalrail.co.uk/stations_destinations/VIC.aspx), in the City of Westminster. *Services:*
 - **Southeastern** (<https://www.southeasternrailway.co.uk/>) from Kent including Ashford, Canterbury, Ramsgate and Margate.
 - **Southern** (<https://www.southernrailway.com/>) from the South East including Gatwick Airport (✈), Bognor Regis, Epsom and Portsmouth with ferries from  France and  Spain (⚓).
 - **Gatwick Express** (<https://www.gatwickexpress.com>) direct train from Gatwick Airport (✈) and Brighton.
 - **Connections at London Victoria** are: **CIR** **DIS** **VIC** (updated Aug 2024 |)

By coach

Most international and domestic long distance coach (U.S. English: bus) services arrive at and depart from a complex of coach stations off Buckingham Palace Road in Westminster close to London Victoria rail station. Virtually all services operate from **21 London Victoria Coach Station** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/coaches/victoria-coach-station>), which has separate arrival and departure buildings. Some services by smaller operators may use the **22 Green Line Coach Station** (<https://www.arrivabus.co.uk/greenline>) nearby.

Listed below are the main coach operators. It is strongly recommended to book your travel in advance: fares can be much cheaper (even a day or two can make all the difference) and you avoid ticket office queues and potentially sold-out coaches. All large and many smaller coach operators allow passengers to show tickets on their mobile phone, and all will allow passengers to print tickets at home.



Terminal stations of London.



Domestic

- **National Express** (<http://nationalexpress.com/>), ☎ +44 870 580 8080. By far the largest domestic coach operator and operates services throughout Great Britain. Fares are fairly low (although usually higher than Megabus): especially when booked in advance via the web. (updated Jun 2017 |)
- **Megabus** (<http://uk.megabus.com>), ☎ +44 141 352-4444 (answered by Citylink). Operates budget coach services between London and various other UK cities, and even to get to Inverness in the Scottish Highlands. Fares are demand responsive but can be very cheap (£1.50 if you book far enough in advance). (updated Jun 2017 |)

International

- **Eurolines** (<http://eurolines.com/>), ☎ +44 870 514 3219. An associate company of National Express, it runs coach services between London and various cities in Northern Ireland, the Republic of Ireland and continental Europe (with direct services extending as far as Bucharest in Romania). (updated Jun 2017 |)
- **Flixbus** (<https://www.flixbus.com/bus/london>), ☎ +49 30 300 137 300. A German bus company which in 2016 took over Megabus services to and from continental Europe. Services from Paris, Brussels, Amsterdam, and Cologne. (updated Jun 2017 |)
- **BlaBlaCar Bus** (<https://www.blablacar.co.uk/bus/>). A coach company competing on the routes from Paris, Brussels, and Amsterdam. They offer newer coaches with plug sockets, Wi-Fi and reserved seating (which is especially useful for those travelling as a couple or group). (updated Jun 2017 |)
- **Sindbad** (<http://www.sindbad.pl/en>), ☎ +48 77 443 44 44. Coach services from cities throughout Poland to Victoria Coach Station. (updated Jun 2017 |)
- **Transmarian** (<https://transmarian.ro/anglia/>), ☎ +40 740-635-532. Coach services from cities throughout Romania to Victoria Coach Station. (updated Nov 2022 |)
- **RegioJet** (<https://www.regiojet.cz/>), ☎ +420 841 101 101. (formerly Student Agency) A Czech operator with a daily service from Prague, departing from the Green Line Coach Station. (updated Jun 2017 |)

By car

London is signposted on major routes in southern England, The Midlands and parts of Wales. Driving in London can prove expensive or - in heavy traffic - time consuming. You can park at railway stations further afield to catch the train into London if you would prefer not to drive.

Remember to drive on the **left** in the UK, including London.

Roads

Intercity road routes in the UK are called "motorways" with blue signs. Other major routes are known as "A roads". Main routes into London include:

From Scotland, The North and The Midlands:

-  **into north London** - from The North and The Midlands, including Leeds, Sheffield, Nottingham, Leicester and Watford. Also from London Luton Airport.
-  **into north London** - from Scotland, The North and The East Midlands, including Edinburgh, Newcastle upon Tyne and Peterborough.
-  **into west London** - from Birmingham and Oxford.

- **A41 into north-west London** - from Bicester, Aylesbury and Watford.

From the East of England:

- **M11/A1 into north-east London** - from Norwich (via A11), Cambridge and Harlow. Also from London Stansted Airport.
- **A10 into north London** - from Hertford.
- **A12 into east London** - from Ipswich, Colchester and Chelmsford. Also from Harwich (via A120, ferries from Hook of Holland, Netherlands).
- **A13 into east London** - from Southend and Tilbury.
- **A127 into east London** - from Southend and Basildon. Also from London Southend Airport.

From Kent and France:

- **M20/A20 into south-east London** - from Kent, including Ashford and Dover, a port town. Also from Channel Tunnel (car shuttle trains from Calais, France).
- **A2 into south-east London** - from Kent, including Dartford, Gravesend, Canterbury and Dover, a port town.

From The South, The South West and Wales:

- **M3/A316 into south-west London** - from Southampton, a port city.
- **M4/A4 into west London** - from Wales and The South West, including Cardiff, Swansea, Bristol and Reading. Fastest route from Fishguard (ferries from Rosslare, Ireland).
- **M23/A23 into south London** - from Brighton and Crawley. Also from London Gatwick Airport.
- **A3 into south-west London** - from Portsmouth, a port city, the South Downs National Park and Guildford.
- **A21 into south-west London** - from Hastings.

You can use several orbital routes and ring roads to get into different parts of London once you are on the city's edges. These are:

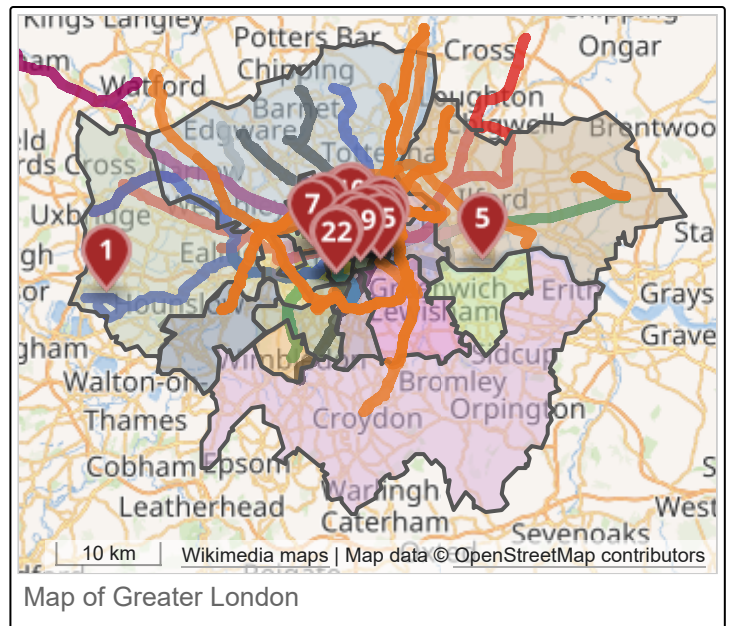
- **M25 London Orbital** - Sometimes known as "Britain's biggest car park", the M25 can be busy. All major routes from other UK cities intersect with the London Orbital. The M25 runs around the outermost edge of London and some of the surrounding towns. There is a charge to cross the Dartford Crossing to the east of London. You can find out more about the Dart Charge on the UK Government website (<https://www.gov.uk/pay-dartford-crossing-charge>).
- **A205 South Circular Road** - Intersects with all major routes south of the River Thames. Passes through Kew, Putney, Clapham, Dulwich, Eltham and Woolwich.
- **A406 North Circular Road** - Intersects with all major routes north of the River Thames. Mostly dual-carriageway. Passes through Ealing, Wembley, Brent Cross, Finchley, Tottenham and Ilford.
- **London Inner Ring Road** - Connects Paddington, Marylebone, King's Cross, Angel, Shoreditch, Tower Bridge, Elephant and Castle, Kennington, Vauxhall, Victoria and Park Lane.

Get around

The main travel options in summary are:

- **By bus:** Running by iconic red double-decker buses, this is the cheapest and usually the best way to get around London as a tourist: on most of the Underground, you won't see anything!

- **By Tube / Underground:** As world's oldest rapid transit system, there're 11 lines cover the central area and northern suburbs, run by TfL.
- **By Overground and the Elizabeth Line:** Urban commuter rail systems run between central area and suburbs, part of National Rail network but run by TfL.
- **By National Rail:** A complex network of suburban rail services mainly covering southern suburbs, privately run and not part of the TfL network, although all operators now accept Oyster payments within Greater London.
- **By Docklands Light Railway (DLR):** An automatic metro system running from the City to East London via the Docklands, run by TfL.
- **By foot:** In central London, walking to the next Tube station often takes around 10 minutes, and is a more scenic choice than going underground. The street layout can be confusing, so a street map is essential; map and travel apps for smartphones and tablets are incredibly useful and many stations have central London printed maps for £2.
- **By boat:** Both commuter ferries run by TfL and pleasure cruises ply along the River Thames. Some services accept Oyster cards, but special fares apply, so check before you travel.
- **By bicycle:** There are hire bicycles (known to Londoners as "Boris Bikes" after former London mayor Boris Johnson) operated by TfL available for pick up in inner London. You will need a credit or debit card with a PIN. If you bring your own bike, there are plenty of cycle lanes and traffic is normally considerate.
- **By tram:** A tram service that operates only in southern suburbs around Croydon, Wimbledon and Bromley. Run by TfL and charges the same fares as buses.



By public transport

London has one of the most comprehensive public transport systems in the world. Despite residents' perpetual (and sometimes justified) grumbling about unreliability, public transport is often the best option for getting anywhere for visitors and residents alike. In central London use a combination of the transport options listed below - and check your map: in many cases, you can easily walk from one place to another or use the buses. Public transportation shuts down early on Christmas Eve, and all day on Christmas Day.

Transport for London (TfL) (<https://tfl.gov.uk/>) is a government organisation responsible for all public transport. Their website contains maps plus an excellent **journey planner** (<http://journeyplanner.tfl.gov.uk>). TfL publishes a useful 'coping guide' (<http://www.tfl.gov.uk/cdn/static/cms/documents/london-visitor-guide.pdf>) specially designed for travellers who wish to use public transport during their visit to London. TfL also offers a 24-hour travel information line, charged at a premium rate: tel +44 843 222 1234 (or text 60835) for suggestions on getting from A to B, and for up to the minute information on how services are running. Fortunately for visitors (and indeed residents) there is a single ticketing system, Oyster, which enables travellers to switch between modes of transport on one ticket.

debit/credit card are charged the same fares as Oyster, using a contactless credit or debit card would be a simpler alternative for most travelers. You can buy an Oyster card from any Tube station for £10 and the cost is *not refundable* (<https://tfl.gov.uk/fares/ways-to-pay/where-to-buy-tickets-and-oyster?intcmp=79977>).

However, your Oyster card, and the credit on it, never expires, so you can keep it as a souvenir and reuse it in case you return to London.

You can "top up" an Oyster card with electronic funds at ticket machines or shops displaying the "Oyster" logo. This money is then deducted according to where you travel. The cost of a single trip using the Oyster card is considerably less than buying a single paper ticket with cash. Prices vary depending on the distance travelled, whether by bus or Tube, and on the time of day. You can also add various electronic seven-day, 1 month and longer-period Travelcards onto an Oyster, and the card is simply validated each time you use it.

You can sign up for contactless and Oyster account (<https://tfl.gov.uk/fares-and-payments/using-your-online-account>). This will allow you to track your journeys and make refund claims for incomplete journeys.

Visitor Oyster card (<https://tfl.gov.uk/travel-information/visiting-london/visitor-oyster-card>)

is a version of the normal Oyster card targeted to travellers. This version of the Oyster card can be purchased from some travel agents outside London and overseas or ordered by mail. This card can also be sent back to TfL by mail after a trip to London to claim a refund for the unused balance. Visitor Oyster cards come pre-charged with pay-as-you-go credit: in increments from £10 to £50. The card itself costs £10 non refundable fee plus postage. With a Visitor Oyster card you can also get some discounts (<https://tfl.gov.uk/travel-information/visiting-london/visitor-oyster-card#on-this-page-8>) in various venues across the city. The Visitor Oyster cards are for pay as you go use only and cannot be registered to provide protection against loss or topped up from the Oyster smart-phone app.

If you have a **National Railcard**, such as the 16-25 Railcard or the Senior Railcard, you can register this with your Oyster card at a Tube station (members of staff near ticket machines can do this) to receive a 33% discount on off-peak pay-as-you-go fares on rail & tube.

Validity of your Oyster

Oyster is valid on all red London buses, and almost all trains in London: a list of destinations is available on the London Rail and Tube Services map (<http://www.tfl.gov.uk/assets/downloads/london-rail-and-tube-services-map.pdf>). Oyster is *not* valid on buses or trains outside London: if

- **River buses** (<http://content.tfl.gov.uk/river-services-map.pdf>) - great if you're near the Thames.
- **Toilets on the Tube** (<http://content.tfl.gov.uk/toilets-map.pdf>) - a map of every TfL station with a public lavatory.

Optimising the cost of travel

The London fare system can be notoriously complex - this is a useful guide that explains how the different services work together, and the different schemes one can use to save a (considerable) amount of money.



Oyster Card



you need to travel beyond the stations on the map, you will have to pay for a paper ticket. Oyster is also not accepted on long-distance coaches, tour buses, or charter buses. Despite being shown on the Tube map, Elizabeth line services from Iver to Reading don't accept Oyster.

The following table summarises the validity of the different tickets you can use on Oyster. For most tourists, the Tube, trains, and buses are the only transport you will use. Although Oyster can be used to and from Heathrow and Gatwick airports, peak fares are charged at all times.

	Bus	Tram	London Underground	London Overground	National Rail (within London)	DLR	Heathrow Express / Gatwick Express	Stansted Express / Luton Airport Express / trains to Southend Airport
Pay-as-you-go	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes; special fares apply	no
Travelcard	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	no	no
Bus & Tram Pass	yes	yes	no	no	no	no	no	no

Using your Oyster card

When using your Oyster card to travel, make sure the reader is displaying an orange light, then place it flat against the reader. A single beep and a green light mean your card has been accepted, and you can proceed. Two beeps and a red light mean your card has not been accepted. Take the card off the reader, wait for the orange light, and try again; if this continues to happen, ask for help from a member of staff. Don't try to insert your Oyster card into the slot at the ticket gates!

When getting on **any kind of train**, you must touch your Oyster card on the yellow circular reader *at the start and end of your journey*. At stations with ticket gates, these readers will be on the right-hand side of the gates. In the outlying parts of the city there are no entry or exit gates at some stations. In this case, the readers are on free-standing cabinets next to entrances/exits. Failing to touch out when you leave a station will result in you being charged a **maximum fare** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/fares-and-payments/maximum-fares>) for your journey, since the system doesn't know which station you left from. The maximum fare is between £5.40 and £14.20, and depends on the station where you started your journey.

Usually you will not need to touch your Oyster card on a reader when **changing trains**. However, some stations have *pink Oyster* "route validators" on the platforms: if you are getting off one train and getting onto another at one of these stations, touch your Oyster on the pink reader so that the system charges you the right fare for the route you have taken. There are a few other situations where you might have to touch out when changing trains (usually when changing between Tube, DLR and/or National Rail) - in these cases make sure you **touch back in** before getting on your next train.

When using a London **bus or a tram**, touch in *once* when getting on. *Don't* touch out when you get off the bus or you will be charged twice. Most buses have their Oyster reader next to the driver. Trams and some buses have Oyster readers on poles next to the doors.

You can make a **change to another bus or a tram** free of charge (<https://tfl.gov.uk/fares/find-fares/bus-and-tram-fares#on-this-page-o>) during one hour. You'll still have to touch your Oyster on the 2nd bus or tram, but no money will be deducted then.

Contactless credit or debit cards or other RFID identity **cards may interfere with your Oyster** if you keep them in the same wallet. This usually results in an error message but may mean you get charged the full fare from your contactless credit or debit card instead. Be careful standing near the readers on some buses - they are often quite sensitive and may read your card from several centimetres away, even if you did not intend this. It is best to remove the card from the wallet or purse it is in.

Pay-as-you-go (PrePay) with your Oyster

You can top up your Oyster card with cash at any Tube station ticket machine or ticket office (you can use a credit card if it has a PIN) with Oyster pay-as-you-go, also known as PrePay. Money is then deducted from your Oyster card each time you travel. When travelling by train, the fare is calculated based on where you started and ended your journey. Pay-as-you-go is much cheaper than paying by cash for each journey, especially if you make multiple trips. Bus fares are flat and you will be charged the same fare every time you get on the bus, regardless of distance.

The amount of Oyster credit deducted from your card in one day is capped to a daily limit. This means that on a day-to-day basis, you will always get the best fares when using Oyster pay-as-you-go. Even if you travel by bus only, your total fares are also capped, this makes bus travel very good value in central London if you are making lots of journeys.

Travelcards

A Travelcard (<https://tfl.gov.uk/fares/how-to-pay-and-where-to-buy-tickets-and-oyster/travelcards-and-group-tickets>) gives you unlimited travel on trains within the relevant zones, and on red London buses. A Travelcard is typically loaded onto your Oyster, but for periods longer than 7 days, you will usually need to register your Oyster card or provide some form of photographic I.D.

For an up-to-date and comprehensive list of fares, see TfL's website (<https://www.tfl.gov.uk/fares-and-payments/>).

If you are using Oyster and travel beyond the zones of your Travelcard, you will be charged an extension fare from your pay-as-you-go credit when you touch out at your destination.

Contactless payment cards

Contactless credit/debit cards, Apple Pay and Google Pay can be used to pay fares (<https://tfl.gov.uk/fares-and-payments/contactless/what-are-contactless-payment-cards>) anywhere Oyster is accepted. Most Visa, MasterCard, Maestro, Cirrus or American Express cards issued outside the UK are accepted. Some pre-paid cards may work as well. Some cards such as Visa contactless cards issued in the United States will not work.

When you enter or leave a station or get on the bus, **touch the card against the yellow validation reader as if it were an Oyster card**. The price is the same as with an Oyster card. The price per day is automatically capped at the price of a day ticket. You also avoid the

queues at ticket machines, the £5 deposit for an Oyster card, and you never have to top it up. A Travelcard can not be loaded onto a contactless card. The same card cannot be used by two or more different passengers. **You must use the same device to touch in and out**, otherwise you may get charged for two journeys - for example, if you touch in using your smartphone but touch out using your physical card, the system may get confused and charge you twice, even if the phone is linked to the same card.

You may notice a charge of £0.10 on your bank statement shortly after you touch in for the first time - this is normal. This will change to the price of all your travel for that day, usually overnight but sometimes it can take a few days.

Using a contactless card as a visitor from abroad may be tricky though. Your bank may ask for additional confirmations, so TfL may suspend accepting a card until you release a pending payment. Also sometimes you may end up with an unfinished journey even though you've touched an exit gate probably because a card may require a bit longer to process after a gate is opened. Keep your card at a reader until the gate opens fully. You can sign up for a contactless and Oyster account (<https://tfl.gov.uk/fares-and-payments/using-your-online-account>) to check for these issues.

Fares

Every station where you can use Oyster or contactless payment is in a "fare zone" from 1 to 9 - you can see what zone a station is in on the Tube Map (look for the shaded areas and numbers in the background). Some stations on the boundary of two zones have their name written in a white box, which means they're considered to be in both zones (for example Earl's Court is in zones 1 and 2). If your journey starts or ends at one of these stations, the system will work out which zone would result in the cheapest fare and charge that.

The price of a journey is determined by how many zones it passes through. In general, the more zones you travel through, the higher the fare, with journeys passing through Zone 1 (most stations in Central London) being more expensive than ones going around it. TfL's website has a single fare finder (<https://tfl.gov.uk/fares/find-fares/tube-and-rail-fares/single-fare-finder>) tool that can be used to work out the price of a journey between any two stations. Most journeys have both a **peak and off-peak** fare - a peak journey is one starting between 06:30 and 09:30 and between 16:00 and 19:00 on working days (excluding public holidays).

Pay as you go fares are **capped**: once the fares for all your journeys on the same day add up to a certain amount (which varies depending on all the zones travelled), any further travel that day will be free. There are also weekly caps, covering all travel within a calendar week. Caps are calculated separately for peak and off-peak travel. Note that, even once you have reached a daily or weekly cap, **you still need to touch in and out** for each journey, otherwise you are traveling without a valid ticket - though you won't be charged anything for it. If you use a combination of Tube, zone 1-6 railway, and bus journeys, the Tube's fare caps (based on the farthest zone you travelled to) will apply to all your journeys for that day.

Paper tickets

It's still possible to pay for a journey by a paper single or return ticket (<https://tfl.gov.uk/fares-and-payments/ways-to-pay/paper-tickets?intcmp=11507>). However, this only makes sense if you take perhaps two to three journeys on public transport during your trip to London as they cost

significantly more (roughly double the cost) in comparison with the other means of payment.

Season tickets can also be purchased in paper.

Accessibility

If you have a physical disability, you might find it harder to travel around London. The oldest parts of the Underground date from the middle of the 19th century, and some of the surface rail network is even older. Therefore, much of the transport system wasn't built to cater for people with disabilities; narrow, winding passageways, steep staircases, and cavernous gaps between some platforms and trains are all barriers for certain passengers.

However, times and attitudes have changed: all stations, lines and trains built since the 1990s are accessible and many older stations have been retrofitted with lifts and ramps. In addition, all London buses and trams have low-floor doors, access ramps and space onboard for at least one wheelchair user; most black cabs (taxis) are also accessible. That said, there are still significant gaps in accessibility, particularly on the Tube in Central London.

To help you navigate, TfL publish several maps to cater for different needs:

- The standard Tube map (<https://content.tfl.gov.uk/standard-tube-map.pdf>) marks all stations that are step-free from either street to platform (white wheelchair symbol) or street to train (blue wheelchair symbol).
- The Step-free Tube map (<https://content.tfl.gov.uk/step-free-tube-guide-map.pdf>) goes into more detail, indicating the height difference between platform and train floor-level.
- The Large-print Tube map (<https://content.tfl.gov.uk/large-print-tube-map.pdf>) and Black-and-white Tube map (<https://content.tfl.gov.uk/bw-large-print-tube-map.pdf>) serve travellers with visual impairments.
- The Audio Tube map (<https://soundcloud.com/transportforlondon/sets/tfl-audio-guide-2016>) is available to stream or download, however as of early 2023 it was last updated in 2016.

For more info, visit the transport accessibility portal (<https://tfl.gov.uk/transport-accessibility/>) on the TfL website.

By Underground

The **London Underground** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/tube/>), known popularly as **the Tube** due to its tube-like tunnels drilled through the London clay, is a network of 11 lines which criss-cross London in one of the largest underground rail networks in the world. It was also the first: the oldest section, from Paddington to Farringdon, opened as the Metropolitan Railway in 1863. The Tube is an easy method of transport even for new visitors to London and is equivalent to subway and metro systems in other world cities.



Geographic Central London
Underground map

The routes operated by the London Underground fall into 2 broad types: the older "sub-surface" lines, encompassing the Metropolitan, District, Circle and Hammersmith & City lines, date from the 19th century. The "deep level" routes were largely

constructed in the early-to-mid-20th century. The sub-surface lines are usually accessed by walking down a short set of stairs, whereas the deep-level lines are accessed by a complicated network of escalators or lifts.

The sub-surface lines use larger trains thanks to their larger tunnel size. The deep-level tube lines are served by the iconic tube-shaped trains which, despite their small size, can only just fit through the tunnels. The deep-level trains do not have air conditioning, which can make them unbearably hot in the summer. Yet the situation will be improved in the future, as TfL will gradually introduce new trains that have air conditioning.

Each line has stations with interesting architectural and artistic features typical of the era they were opened. As you travel around the network, look out for Victorian finery, Edwardian glazed tiles, smooth Art Deco symmetry, and striking modern masterpieces. Various conservation pieces are also present, such as the heritage 1900s station name roundel sign at Caledonian Road on the westbound platform.



London Underground stations are identified with signs like these, and Overground stations have a similar symbol with an orange circle. National Rail stations have a different "double-arrow" symbol.

Trains on most days and on most lines run from around 5:30AM to around 1AM. They are usually the fastest way to travel in London, the only problem being the relative expense and the fact that they can get extremely crowded during rush hours (7:30-10AM and 4:30-7PM). There is no air conditioning on the deep-level trains, which can make them unbearably hot in the summer. TfL's website (<http://tfl.gov.uk>) has a page notifying of tracking delays, closures, and planned engineering works, which you should check if you plan to travel on a Saturday or a Sunday, when entire lines may be shut down due to engineering works.

If you're travelling around central London then taking the Tube for just one stop can be a waste of time. For example, to travel between Leicester Square and Covent Garden stations takes over 10 minutes on the Tube, despite the two stations being only a few minutes walk apart. This is especially true since the walk from a Tube station entrance to the platform at some central stations can be extensive. The Tube map also gives no information on London's extensive bus network, or any of its National Rail network except for Thameslink. For more information see the 'By foot' section.

Night Tube

The **Night Tube** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/campaign/tube-improvements/what-we-are-doing/night-tube?cid=nighttube>) is a limited 24-hour Tube service that operates on certain lines on Fridays and Saturdays.

Night Tube fares are the same as the off-peak fares during the day. Day Travelcards are valid on the day they were issued (using the date printed on the card) and for journeys starting before 4:30AM the following day. For example, if you buy a Day Travelcard at 11AM on Friday, you can use it until 4:29AM on the following Saturday. Daily capping on Oyster cards and contactless payment cards also applies.

As of 2024, the Night Tube services run on the following lines:

- **Central line:** Trains run approximately every 10 minutes between White City and Leytonstone, and approximately every 20 minutes on the Ealing Broadway to White City, and Leytonstone to Loughton/Hainault sections. There is no service between North Acton and West Ruislip, Loughton and Epping, and Woodford and Hainault.
- **Jubilee line:** Trains run every 10 minutes on average along the entire line.
- **Northern line:** Trains run every 15 minutes on average, between High Barnet or Edgware and Morden, via the Charing Cross branch (so every 7-8 minutes between Camden Town and Morden). No service on the Bank branch, or to Battersea Power Station or Mill Hill East.
- **Piccadilly line:** Trains run every 10 minutes on average, between Heathrow Terminals 5 and 2&3 and Cockfosters. No service to Terminal 4, or between Uxbridge and Acton Town.
- **Victoria line:** Trains run every 10 minutes on average along the entire line.
- **London Overground:** Trains run every 15-20 minutes on average along the **Windrush line** between Highbury & Islington and New Cross Gate. No service on other Overground lines.

Ticketing

Travel on the Tube system will always require the purchase of a ticket or the use of an Oyster card or contactless payment card if you have one; fare evasion is treated as a serious matter and will get you a fine.

Single tickets are charged at two rates, depending on the payment method. Cash fares and single Oyster fares are zonal, meaning that the price of a journey is determined by the zones you travelled through. There are additional fares payable for zones beyond 9, but these are mostly outside what is considered London.

Paper travelcards valid for 1 day or 7 days are also available and can also be used on buses, National Rail trains, the DLR and trams - however there is a capping feature for contactless and Oyster cards (which guarantees a strict upper bound on the fare you pay for a day and a week) which means that a paper travelcard is unnecessary and costlier.

Almost all stations have automatic ticket barriers. If you pay by Oyster card or a contactless payment card, just tap your card against the yellow pad to open the barriers (ensure that you do this upon both entrance and exit). If you have a paper ticket, insert it face-up into the slot on the front of the machine, and remove it from the top to enter the station. If you have a single ticket it will be retained at the exit gate. If you have luggage or if your ticket is rejected there is normally a staffed gate as well.

Paper tickets can be purchased from vending machines in the station's ticket hall. The touchscreen machines have instructions in multiple languages, offer a greater choice of ticket and accept bills and credit/debit cards (if your card has no embedded microchip, you cannot use these machines; these machines do not support contactless). You can also add Oyster pay-as-you-go credit on many mainline ticket vending machines in London.

If you have a national train ticket, which involves travelling across London (e.g. Brighton to Darlington), you may be able to travel on the Tube across London, from one London terminus to another. If your train ticket has "Any permitted + " (with the dagger symbol) written in the "Route" section (at the bottom of the ticket), then you are able to travel on the Tube without buying another ticket. These can be used at the ticket barriers in the same way as the paper tickets described above.

Navigation

The Tube is made up of 11 lines each bearing a traditional name and a standard colour on the Tube map (e.g. the Circle line in yellow, Central line in red, Piccadilly line in dark blue). Since the Tube map is well designed it is very easy to work out how to get between any two stations, and since each station is clearly signed it is easy to work out when to exit your train. The Tube map is a diagram and not a scaled map, making it misleading for determining the relative distance between stations as it makes central stations appear further apart and somewhat out of place - the most distant reaches of the Metropolitan Line for example are almost 64 km (40 mi) from the centre of the city. Tube maps are freely available from any station, most tourist offices, and are prominently displayed in stations. The National Rail map (<https://tfl.gov.uk/maps/track/national-rail>) showing National Rail services is displayed as a large poster at most Tube stations.

There are many lines with multiple branches rather than running point-to-point, and it's also possible that some trains will not run the full line, so always check the train's destination, which is shown on the front of the train and the platform indicator screens, and will be broadcast on the train's PA. A typical announcement will be like: "This is a Piccadilly line service to Cockfosters."

Most branches are only served by specific services; from the eastern end of the District line at Upminster, for instance, you can only catch trains for Ealing Broadway and Richmond - if you want to go to Wimbledon, you will have to change trains later down the line, like at Earl's Court.

Normally trains stop at all stations with the exception of the Metropolitan line, which have *semi-fast* and *fast* service patterns from Amersham and Chesham, that skip all stations between Moor Park and Harrow-on-the-Hill (fast only), and between Harrow-on-the-Hill and Wembley Park. It's also possible that some stations may closed due to some reason, and trains will not stop there, so please pay attention on announcements for any service changes.

There are several sections where more than one line will **share tracks** with others, or even other services (like Overground and National Rail services), which they may stop at the same platform, so you should pay extra attention for the right train. Mostly you can differentiate the different services by the type of train, though this is not possible on the **Circle, District, Hammersmith & City and Metropolitan lines**, since all four use the same rolling stock on shared lines. Here you will need to pay attention to announcements and signs on the platform and trains.

Signs can be vague, especially if you are unfamiliar with what compass point direction (e.g. northbound) you're travelling in, as these are most often given rather than destinations. A person new to the Tube can become very frustrated trying to work out where a particular connection at a particular station is found. Central and busy stations are staffed by at least two members of staff at all times who can advise you on your route and full system maps are on the walls of every platform and ticket office. Additionally, on every platform, there are individual line maps showing all the stations served by trains calling at that platform. It is always advisable to carry a pocket Tube map to help you with this; the TfL Go and Citymapper apps are also handy tools.

The **Northern line** has two routes through central London which split at Euston and rejoin at Kennington. The Charing Cross branch runs through the West End, while the Bank branch runs through the City of London. To work out which way your train is going, check the signs above the platform, and on the front of the train. The train's destination and central branch will also be

announced on board, for example "This is a Northern line train via Charing Cross, terminating at Edgware." A similar announcement will also appear on the **Hainault Loop** section on the **Central line** in North East London.

The London Underground has connections to all terminals at Heathrow and most major London rail termini, with the exception of Fenchurch Street (although this is walking distance from Tower Hill and Aldgate). Interchange hubs are also served, such as Farringdon, Elephant & Castle, Harrow & Wealdstone and Stratford.

Onboard

Be considerate of your fellow passengers as best you can. Pushing and rushing are seen as extremely rude - there's not much need to run for a Tube train unless it's the very last one of the day! Also, trying to strike up a conversation with strangers is seen as peculiar and will instantly mark you out as a tourist. Despite having a reputation as being aloof Londoners are usually happy to help out if you have a problem, but otherwise they'd rather you didn't try to be overly familiar.

In some cases (particularly for the sub-surface lines), the tube doors have buttons on the outside. They normally come to use if a train is waiting for over 45 seconds, as the doors will automatically close to conserve energy. *If* the train isn't ready to depart (which is easy to check - if the button isn't illuminated, the train is ready to depart), pressing the button will open the doors.

Crime, safety, and accidents

When using the escalators, **always stand on the right** to allow people in a hurry to pass. Drinking alcohol or smoking anywhere on the London Underground is illegal.

Crime levels on the Tube are comparable to but typically lower than in many other subway systems, and traveller advice about watching luggage and valuables is reasonable. The Tube system is covered by an extensive CCTV system, although it is not advised to be reliant on this fact when travelling.

The London Underground considers its safety record to be a matter of professional honour, major incidents being incredibly rare (despite the media attention they generate). Front-line staff are well trained for emergencies and will follow well-rehearsed procedures. In addition, front-line staff are generally appreciative of traveller vigilance, if concerns are politely expressed. If you notice something that concerns you please speak to a member of staff or a British Transport Police officer.

Getting help

On the wall of the platforms (or freestanding on outdoor platforms) there will be a round, white device labelled "Help Point" with one or two buttons and a fire alarm. Press the green button to alert staff to an emergency and press the blue button to ask for non-urgent assistance. If you see smoke or fire always use the fire alarm first.

On the train

On Tube trains you will notice that there is a red handle you can pull to alert the driver to a serious incident or accident occurring on the train. If the train is in a tunnel the alarm should only be used in dire emergencies that require immediate attention, as pulling the alarm will activate the train's brakes. In practice, when the alarm is activated, a driver will move the train forward into the next station where help can be obtained. Therefore, the alarms should only be used in stations if possible as passengers will then be able to escape the train quickly if needed.

TfL advise travellers to carefully consider their usage of the passenger alarm and, if suitable, leave the train at the next station and seek help from station staff instead. Because trains on the London Underground are run close together any delays can have serious knock-on effects for the rest of the service. In contrast, train drivers vary in their opinion as to when the alarm should be used: Consensus tends to be that if it's something you would run down the train to tell the driver then the alarm should definitely be used.

Lost items

Owing to a heightened security climate, and a history of political violence targeting the Tube, unattended baggage may be treated as a suspect or explosive device and may be destroyed. Lost items (if not destroyed) will end up at the **Lost Property Office** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/help-and-contact/lost-property>) and will be stored for 3 months. You will need to fill in a form online describing your lost item and TfL will contact you if it is found. There is a charge for recovery of most items, however some items (e.g. Laptops) have higher fees.

By bus

London's iconic red **Routemaster** buses, which are recognised the world over, were withdrawn from regular service in 2005. Although a heritage service was continued on portions of two routes, this ceased in 2019. Routemasters are still used for tours and private parties.

Buses are generally quicker than taking the Tube for shorter (less than a couple of stops on the Tube) trips, and out of central London you're likely to be closer to a bus stop than a Tube station. Most buses in London are very frequent (at least every ten minutes) and are accessible for buggies and wheelchairs. Buses also have a flat rate fare which stays the same no matter how far you travel. You will need to pay the fare again if you board a different bus, although the Hopper fare allows you to take as many buses as you like in 62 minutes and only pay for the first one.

Over 5 million bus trips are made each weekday; with over 700 different bus routes you are never far from a bus. Each bus stop has a sign listing the routes that stop there and bus routes are identified by



London is covered by Europe's biggest bus network.



numbers and sometimes letters. Buses have very clear *blinds* on the front, with their route number and their destination. Transport for London produces all Bus route maps (<https://tfl.gov.uk/maps/bus?intcmp=40401>).

"Superloop" express buses operate mainly in the suburbs and have numbers beginning with an SL prefix. Some of them are operated using specially branded buses with a red and cream livery. There is no difference in fare between them and ordinary buses, but you need to check that they will stop at the place you want to get off. They are "express" in the sense that they only stop at major locations along their routes, but they can still be slowed down by traffic. There is also the unique "Bakerloop" express route BL1 which runs along the route of a proposed extension of the Bakerloo Line in South-East London.

Using the bus

When you see your bus approaching, **signal clearly to the driver** that you intend to get on their bus: the way to do this is to stick your hand out, with an open palm. The driver will indicate and pull into the stop. Always wait for people to get off the bus before you enter.

Most buses have **two doors**. Form an orderly queue at the front door: when you reach the driver, touch your Oyster or contactless payment card on the reader or show them your Travelcard or pass (importantly, cash is *not* accepted). Some buses are worked by the "New Routemaster" which has three doors, the front door being the entrance and the middle and rear doors the exits. It should be noted that unlike the Tube, you are allowed to use an Oyster card which has zero (but not negative) or insufficient balance - this will cause the balance to be negative (the machines will flash an "Emergency fare charged" message which is the same as the normal fare); however, you must then recharge before the card can be used again.

If you are a wheelchair user, you should indicate as normal, and wait by the second door from the front. The driver will activate the wheelchair ramp for you to use.

Most buses have a system that provides visual and audible announcements of the bus's destination at every stop, the stops, and nearby landmarks.

When you are nearing your stop, press one of the red "STOP" buttons on the handrails **once only**. You'll hear a bell, or a buzzer, and the words "Bus Stopping" will appear on the destination screen. Get off the bus using the middle or rear door. There is also a blue "stop" button by the wheelchair space - this indicates to the driver that the wheelchair ramp is required at the next stop.

Bus tips

- Buses can accelerate and brake very fast so always grab hold of one of the handrails if standing.
- If you are taking a pram/buggy with you, you must be prepared to fold it and carry your child if the bus is crowded or if a wheelchair user needs to get on the bus.
- Smoking and drinking alcohol is not allowed on buses. Non-alcoholic drinks and most food is fine, but be considerate: fast food is often smelly and leaves a mess.
- No standing on the upper deck or stairs.
- Don't speak to the driver or try to get their attention when the bus is moving unless it is an emergency.
- Some buses terminate early and don't run the full length of the route. Always check the destination blind on the front of the bus, and if in doubt, ask the driver or the conductor. Drivers will *usually* announce a change in the bus's destination.
- If your bus terminates early and you have paid using Oyster or contactless debit/credit card, the "Hopper" fare will automatically come into force, meaning that if you scan into another bus within one hour of scanning into the first bus you will not be charged.

Finally, **always watch out for moving traffic**, cyclists and pedestrians, when you get off the bus.

Fares

It is **not possible to buy tickets on the bus** so you must have a valid Travelcard, Oyster card or contactless credit or debit card before you get on. Alternatively, tickets may be purchased from most newsagents in London, or from ticket machines at certain central London stops. The adult bus fare is £1.75; discounts are available to holders of certain cards that must be applied for in advance.

Unlike on the Tube, you are charged for each bus you travel on. If you change buses then you will normally be charged a new bus fare up to the daily/weekly price cap. However, the **Hopper fare** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/fares/find-fares/bus-and-tram-fares#on-this-page-o>) allows you to make unlimited bus or tram journeys for the price of one if you use an Oyster card or contactless payment method. All of your journeys must be made within an hour of touching in on the first bus or tram you are travelling on and you must also use the same Oyster or contactless card for the other journeys. There is no need to tell the driver you want this, it will happen automatically.

Oyster

If you have a seven-day, monthly or yearly Travelcard or Bus and Tram Pass on your Oyster, that includes free bus travel across all of London, even outside the zones of your Travelcard (buses aren't subject to zones). You still must touch in when you get on the bus, but you won't be charged.

If you do not have a Travelcard, the fare is taken from your Oyster pay as you go credit as soon as you touch in when you get on the bus. Daily bus and tram travel is "capped", so you generally won't pay more than an equivalent travelcard.

Unlike the Tube, you are allowed to use an Oyster card which has zero (but not negative) or insufficient balance - this will cause the balance to be negative (the machines will flash an "Emergency fare charged" message which is the same as the normal fare); however, you must then recharge before the card can be used again.

Touch your Oyster on the reader as soon as you get on the bus or you may be liable to a Penalty Fare or prosecution.

Contactless credit, debit or prepaid cards

You can also pay for with most contactless debit, credit or prepaid Visa, MasterCard/Maestro or American Express cards. You touch the card flat against the reader, like you would with an Oyster card, but your account is charged instead. Some foreign-issued cards will not work for contactless payment.

The total charges for that day are calculated and taken out of your account overnight. As with Oyster, you are charged for each bus fare, up to a cap each day. In addition, a weekly price cap applies from Monday to Sunday.

See [above](#) for further information on contactless payment.

Concessions

Children aged 10 and under travel for free on the bus when accompanied by an adult. Children between the ages of 11 and 15 must touch in using a Zip card, yet journeys are still free on buses. If they do not have a Zip card they must pay the full fare using an adult Oyster or contactless card. 16-18 Student Oyster cards (only available to students studying in London) go up to age 18 and journeys are still free. Residents of England who have an ENCTS free bus pass (for the elderly or disabled) also get free travel: simply show your pass to the driver or conductor.

Night buses

Standard bus services run from around 6AM-12:30AM. Around half past midnight the network changes to the vast night bus network of well over 100 routes stretching all over the city. There are two types of night buses: 24-hour routes and N-prefixed routes.

24-hour services keep the same number as during the day and will run exactly the same route, such as the number 88, for example. N-prefixed routes are generally very similar to their day-route, but may take a slightly different route or are extended to serve areas that are further out. For example, the 29 bus goes from Trafalgar Square to Wood Green during the day; however, the N29 bus goes from Trafalgar Square to Wood Green and then continues to Enfield.

Night buses run at a 30-minute frequency at minimum, with many routes at much higher frequencies up to every 5 minutes.

Prices stay the same, and daily Travelcards are valid until 04:29 the day after they were issued, so can be used on night buses. Most bus stops will have night bus maps with all the buses to and from that local area on it, although it is good to check on the TfL website beforehand, which also has all those maps easily available.

By DLR

Docklands Light Railway (DLR) (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/dlr/>) is a dedicated light rail network operating in East London, connecting with the Tube network at Bank, Tower Gateway (close to Tower Hill station), Canning Town, Heron Quays (close to Canary Wharf Tube station), and Stratford. As the trains operate automatically, it can be quite exciting – especially for children – to sit at the front and look out through the window, whilst feeling as though one is driving the train oneself. The DLR runs above ground on much of its route, and travels through many scenic parts of London, including the Docklands area where most of London's skyscrapers are located.

The DLR can be a little confusing as the routes are not easily distinguished, however there are network maps on the train and the platform. Check the displays on the platform which will show you the destination and the wait for the next three trains, and also check the destination displays

Night bus hints

- While Britons on public transport are normally a model of reserve, those using night buses have a bit of a reputation for loud and rowdy behaviour. Their passengers are often people who have been having a good time in central London's clubs and bars; particularly true on buses leaving central London between 1AM and 3AM. While the buses are normally quite safe, if this is a concern for you, consider taking a pre-booked minicab instead, or failing that stand on the lower deck of the bus nearest the driver.
- **Always call out to the driver if you are pickpocketed, threatened or attacked.**

on the front and side of the train and listen for announcements. At busy times, some trains do not run the full length of the route. In this instance, you should take the first train, listen for announcements, and change where necessary.

Be extra careful at **Canning Town** station, as it is very busy and four different DLR lines run through it. Use station signage to work out which platform you need; for example all services towards Stratford International use platform 2. Always check the destination on the front of the train and related announcements before getting on, especially at off-peak times, when there may not be a train taking you back on track for a good few minutes, if you end up on the wrong branch.

Ticketing

Unlike on the Tube, most DLR stations do not have ticket gates (except for Bank and Stratford) as they are unstaffed. Also, unlike the Tube, you *do* need to push the buttons to open the doors.

You can top up an Oyster card, buy a Travelcard or buy a paper ticket (at a substantial premium) from the ticket machines at the station. Most stations are unstaffed, so if you want to pay by cash then make sure you have plenty of change! As there are no gates, when travelling by Oyster you must always remember to touch in at the start of your journey and touch out at the end. Even if you are changing to the Underground at Canary Wharf/Heron Quays, you must still touch in/out at the DLR station: the system will recognise that you have made an interchange between the two stations and treat it as part of the same journey.

By train

Wikivoyage has a guide to Rail travel in Great Britain, with information applicable to the National Rail system within London.

The British railway system is known as **National Rail** (although some older signs still refer to it as "British Rail"). London's suburban rail services are operated by several private companies under tightly-written government contracts, and mostly run in the south of the city away from the main tourist sights. Only one line (Thameslink) runs through central London - on a north-south axis between London Bridge or Blackfriars stations, and the underground level of St Pancras main line station. There is no one central station - instead, there are twelve mainline stations dotted around the edge of the central area, and most are connected by the Circle line (except Euston, Fenchurch Street and those south of the river like Waterloo and London Bridge).

Most visitors will not need to use National Rail services except for a few specific destinations such as Wimbledon, Hampton Court, Kew Gardens (Kew Bridge station), Windsor Castle, Greenwich, or the airports, or indeed if they are intending to visit other destinations in the UK.



St Pancras Railway Station, one of the  grandest in Europe

It's important to know that the quickest route between two stations is often a combination of the Tube as well as National Rail trains. For instance, if you are going from central London to Wimbledon, it will usually be much quicker to go to Waterloo and take the first Wimbledon train (around 15 minutes, maximum) rather than take the District line, which can take up to 45 minutes.

Your pay-as-you-go Oyster card is valid in London zones 1-9 (and some extensions), but not beyond, so be careful — if you want to travel beyond the London zones you will need to buy a paper ticket from the ticket office at the station. If you travel beyond the London zones with no valid ticket, you will be charged a Penalty Fare (on National Rail services this is usually £20), you will have to buy another ticket for the remainder of your journey, and you will also be charged the maximum Oyster fare because you didn't touch out. This adds up to a lot, so be careful and make sure you plan your journey! If in doubt, ask at the ticket office. Importantly, there are stations where contactless payment *but not* Oyster is accepted - watch out for them.

There are express trains to and from Heathrow, Gatwick and Stansted airports. Tickets are often sold at a substantial premium, so you may want to consider taking the slightly slower 'stopping' services instead: for instance, an Anytime single from Victoria to Gatwick costs more on the Gatwick Express, then when marked "Route Southern Only"—taking a Southern train to Gatwick is only eight minutes longer. Similarly, while the journey from Paddington station to Heathrow Airport by Elizabeth Line will take around 10-15 minutes longer than by Heathrow Express, the walk-up fare will be twice as cheap (and even cheaper on the Tube, though the journey takes considerably longer), so it's often only worth the premium when you're in a hurry. **Oyster cards are only valid** to Heathrow when travelling by Tube, Heathrow Express, or the Elizabeth Line, to Gatwick by National Rail (including Gatwick Express), and to City by DLR. To all other airports they are not valid.

Don't throw your ticket away until you're out of the station at your destination! Many stations have ticket gates which you will need to put your ticket through to exit; also, you need to retain all the parts of your ticket throughout your journey, as a member of railway staff may need to see it.

By Overground

In common parlance, Londoners may refer to travelling by "overground", meaning going by National Rail (as opposed to going by Underground). However, only **London Overground** is a Transport for London rail service, which serves most boroughs of the capital. Oyster cards are accepted. Trains will usually run a minimum frequency of every 15 minutes, and some stations have a considerably more frequent service. The trains have big windows allowing for great "urban scenic" views.

The Overground appears on the Tube map as a double orange line. TfL also produces a [map only showing Overground services](http://content.tfl.gov.uk/london-overground-network-map.pdf) (<http://content.tfl.gov.uk/london-overground-network-map.pdf>). At many stations, trains

Overground hints

- Beware of pickpockets. Don't openly display your phone, wallet and other valuables.
- Drinking alcohol or smoking anywhere on the Overground is illegal.
- Always stand **well behind** the yellow line painted on the platform. At some stations on the North London and West London lines freight trains run in the gap between Overground trains - because these trains are not stopping they can travel through stations at speed. Turbulence from these trains is dangerous.

leaving from the same platform will go to different destinations, so listen carefully for announcements and always check the destination on the front of the train. The Overground can be a great way to avoid changing trains in central London by skirting around the centre. It's also well-connected: you can frequently change for Underground trains, other Overground destinations, or for mainline National Rail services from Stratford, Clapham Junction and Watford Junction.

The different Overground services were given distinct line names and colours from autumn 2024:

- **Liberty line** (■ grey) between Romford and Upminster.
- **Lioness line** (■ yellow) between Euston and Watford Junction.
- **Mildmay line** (■ blue) between Stratford and Willesden Junction, where it splits into two branches to Richmond and Clapham Junction.
- **Suffragette line** (■ light green) between Gospel Oak and Barking Riverside.
- **Weaver line** (■ purple/maroon) starting at Liverpool Street, with three branches to Chingford, Cheshunt and Enfield Town.
- **Windrush line** (■ red/pink) starting at Highbury and Islington, with four branches to Clapham Junction, New Cross, Crystal Place and West Croydon.

- Most Overground trains have "walk-through" carriages with no doors separating each car. If the train is busy, try moving to the other end or towards the centre.
- Give up your seat to the elderly and those less able to stand, especially if the seat is labelled "Priority Seat." These seats are a slightly different shade of orange than most seats.
- **The doors on the Overground will not open automatically.** Wait for the button to light up and start beeping, then push it to open the train doors.
- Trains will usually run every 15 minutes or less, and more frequently on busy routes.
- Do not use flash photography or tripods when taking photographs. A camera flash can distract train drivers and tripods are not safe on the platform.
- The Lioness Line at Euston and the Weaver Line at Liverpool Street do not have dedicated platforms but use the same platforms as National Rail trains, so you need to check the departure board to see where to board your train. This sometimes confuses visitors.

By the Elizabeth line

The **Elizabeth line** is London's newest railway line. It appears on the Tube map as a double purple line. It runs from Reading and Heathrow Airport in the west to Abbey Wood and Shenfield in the east via London Paddington, Farringdon, London Liverpool St and Stratford. Compared to the Underground, it has longer and faster trains that stop less frequently. It is fully wheelchair-accessible (although boarding ramps are necessary at some stations) and the trains are air-conditioned.



Elizabeth line roundel



By Tram

The **London Trams** network is centred on Croydon, where it runs on street-level tracks around the Croydon Loop, providing transit to an area not well-served by the Tube or National Rail. Route 3 (Wimbledon to New Addington - green on the tram map) is the most frequent service, running every 7 or 8 minutes Monday to Saturday

daytime and every 15 minutes at all other times. Beckenham is served by Routes 1 and 2 (yellow and red on the tram map), which terminate at Elmers End and Beckenham Junction respectively. All services travel around the Loop via West Croydon and run every 10 minutes Monday to Saturday daytime and every 30 minutes at all other times. Between Arena and Sandilands, these two services serve the same stops.

On foot

London is a surprisingly compact city, making it a walker's delight. In many instances, walking is the quickest method of transport between two points.

Because Britain drives on the left hand side of the road, for most foreign visitors it can be all too easy to forget that traffic will come at you from the opposite direction than you are used to when crossing a street - for this reason **remember to look right when you cross the road**. If you are using a pedestrian crossing, don't risk it even if you can't see any traffic coming: Wait for the green man to appear and then cross quickly and carefully. Some pedestrian crossings now have countdown timers to indicate how long it will be safe to cross for.



Regent Street



Particularly on Central London's busiest streets, it is easy to spot native Londoners as they weave in and out of the large crowds at fast speed; tourists who cannot will stand out. Make sure you're aware of your surroundings when in London—Londoners are usually very considerate, but a group of tourists standing in the middle of the pavement can be a major annoyance! Try standing to the side of busy pavements and footpaths, especially if you're with a group.

Walking alternatives to the Tube

In some instances, it can be faster to walk some or all of your intended route instead of taking the Tube. By looking at a map you'll notice that some central London Tube stations are a lot closer together than the Tube map would make you believe.

Here are some more specific instructions for some of the stations that you are likely to use as a tourist:

- **Leicester Square station – Covent Garden station:** Come out of the station with The Hippodrome Casino behind you. Cross Charing Cross Road and walk up Cranbourn Street. Walk straight over at the junction and continue onto Long Acre. Walk straight up Long Acre to arrive at Covent Garden station. **Approximate walking time:** 5 minutes
- **Holborn station – Covent Garden station:** Exit the station onto Kingsway, opposite a large Sainsbury's shop (if you exit onto High Holborn opposite a McDonald's - turn left, and round the corner). Cross Kingsway (this is a very busy road), and turn left on the other side. Take the second right (by a Starbucks) onto Great Queen Street. Walk straight, crossing over Drury Lane onto Long Acre. Continue on Long Acre, crossing over Endell Street/Bow Street. Covent Garden station will be on your left. **Approximate walking time:** 10 minutes.
- **Embankment station – Waterloo station:** Come out of the station onto Victoria Embankment, walk up the stairs and head across the River Thames using the Hungerford Bridge. At the other end of the bridge keep walking straight and away from the River

Thames. Follow the railway line. You will come to some blue metal work and a walkway underneath the railway line called Sutton Walk. Follow this, cross the road and Waterloo station is ahead of you. **Approximate walking time:** 15 minutes

- **Westminster station – Waterloo station:** Come out of the station and head across the River Thames using Westminster Bridge. Keep heading straight until you come to a junction. Turn left and walk down York Road. Stay on York Road until you come to a railway bridge. Waterloo station will be on your right. **Approximate walking time:** 15 minutes
- **Green Park station – Hyde Park Corner station:** Come out of Green Park station onto the road. This is Piccadilly. Walk west along Piccadilly following the edge of Green Park. When you come to a roundabout head straight across it. Hyde Park Corner station will be on your right. **Approximate walking time:** 10 minutes
- **Queensway – Bayswater:** Turn to the left when exiting the station and keep walking. This is a good route if you want to quickly change to a different Tube line but not change at Notting Hill Gate. **Approximate walking time:** 1 minute

Oxford Circus station

Oxford Circus station can become extremely busy on weekday evenings and, if convenient, it is worth walking to other Tube stations.

- **Oxford Circus station – Bond Street station:** Head west along Oxford Street from the road junction. You should see the London College of Fashion and BHS. Keep walking west and you will come to Bond Street station. **Approximate walking time:** 10 minutes.
- **Oxford Circus station – Tottenham Court Road station:** At the road junction, head east along Oxford Street heading past Topshop. Keep walking past H&M and McDonald's and you will eventually see a skyscraper called Centre Point. Continue heading straight and Tottenham Court Road station is on the road junction here. **Approximate walking time:** 25 minutes.
- **Oxford Circus – Piccadilly Circus station:** At the road junction, head south along Regent Street to pass many big name brands, including Apple and Hamleys. Just after the road curves round to the left, you should be at Piccadilly Circus. **Approximate walking time:** 10 minutes.

By bicycle

Due to the expense of other forms of transport and the compactness of central London, cycling is a tempting option. Free cycle maps can usually be obtained from your local Tube station or bike shop.

Most major roads in London will have a bus lane which is restricted to buses, taxis and bicycles. There are also many signposted cycle routes and cycle lanes, but the kind of contiguous cycle lane network found in many other European cities does not exist. The safest option is to stick to minor residential roads where traffic can be surprisingly calm outside rush hours.

Critical Mass London is a cycling advocacy group which meets for regular rides through central London at 6PM on the last Friday of each month. Rides start from the southern end of Waterloo Bridge. The London Cycling

Cycling in the United Kingdom

- **Cycling on the pavement (sidewalk) is illegal**, except where a cycle route has been designated by signs or painted lines.
- When cycling on roads, you must ride on the left with other vehicles.
- You must have working front and rear lights during hours of darkness. Flashing LED lights are legal. Reflective clothing is always a good idea at night.
- Helmets are not compulsory for cyclists in the United Kingdom, and their effectiveness is as much a matter of debate here as anywhere else. In London, many cyclists, especially those

Campaign (<http://lcc.org.uk>) is an advocacy group for London cyclists. With active local groups in most of the city's boroughs, it is recognised by the local and regional governments as the leading voice for cycling in the capital.

Normally a cyclist should keep to the left of the lane when cycling on a road with traffic, to allow faster-moving traffic to overtake. However, it is legal for a cycle to dominate a lane by maintaining a central road position like any other vehicle. This will make you unpopular with any traffic behind you but it is recommended in London on approach to right-hand turns at junctions. Making a right-hand turn from the normal left-position means crossing the lane of traffic, which may often ignore you and any turn signals you might have been using, leading to potential accidents.

Taking bikes on trains

Permission to take bikes on trains is very limited in London due to overcrowding. Non-folding bikes can be taken only on limited sections of the Tube network, mostly only on the above-ground sections outside peak hours. For this reason, folding bicycles are becoming increasingly popular. Most *National Rail* operators allow bicycles outside peak hours.

Bicycle hire

London offers a bicycle hire scheme known as **Santander Cycles** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/cycling/santander-cycles>), operated by Transport for London. They are colloquially referred to as "Boris Bikes" after Boris Johnson, as they were introduced during his period as mayor of London. Docking stations can be found across Central London and slightly further out into areas such as Brixton, the Docklands, Hammersmith, and the Queen Elizabeth Olympic Park.

The bikes, all coloured a distinctive red, can be unlocked at any hire dock and then ridden to wherever you want. After each journey the bike must be returned to a docking station on the network by locking the bike into the rack and receiving confirmation via a green light.

You pay via a credit or debit card and two payment plans exist: daily and yearly. A £2 daily plan (as of October 2020) gives access to the system for an unlimited number of rides for 24 hours. A fee for the first 30 minutes of each ride is included in the initial payment. For every other 30 minutes above that it costs extra £2. A yearly plan costs £90 for a full year.

The **Santander Cycles** app (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/cycling/santander-cycles/community>) shows where bikes are available and can be used to make the hiring process faster, although sometimes the app doesn't show a journey as finished even if the bike was successfully docked

seen in rush hour, also wear filter masks, but their efficacy is even more disputed.

- It is illegal to jump through a red light for cyclists as well as motorists. Advance stop lines at traffic lights allow cyclists to wait ahead of other traffic at red lights. In practice, most car drivers ignore this and occupy the cycle space when waiting at lights.
- When approaching a zebra crossing you should always take care and watch for pedestrians waiting to cross the road. You *must* be prepared to slow down or stop to allow them to cross as detailed in Rule 195 of the Highway Code (<https://www.gov.uk/guidance/the-highway-code/using-the-road-159-to-203>). **If someone is on a crossing already, you must stop as a car or other vehicle would and allow them to cross safely - weaving around pedestrians may frighten them and lead to an accident!**

The rules for cyclists are available in the British Government publication **The Highway Code** (<http://www.direct.gov.uk/en/TravelAndTransport/Highwaycode/Cyclists/index.htm>)

back at a station. If in doubt it's better to check your activity log on the official site.

The Santander bikes' main competitor is **Lime** (<https://www.li.me/locations/uk>), whose fleet of electric bikes can be parked almost anywhere in much of Inner London, not just at docking stations. Download the app and set up a payment method first, then use your phone to scan a bike and unlock it. Rides are £1 plus £0.15 per minute (February 2021).

Cycle ways

Cycle lanes provide on-road and off-road routes. The network is not comprehensive, and on the road lanes vary in quality and size (normally 1-2 m wide). Some are indicated just with a stencilled image of a bike on the road. If the line between the traffic lane and cycle lane is solid, then vehicles may sometimes enter the space. A dashed line indicates a recommended cycle lane and motorists may make use of this road space, but it's recommended that they don't.

London's **cycleways** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/cycling/routes-and-maps/cycleways>) connect destinations across the capital, and include "cycle superhighways" and "quietways". **Cycle Superhighways** run into central London from outer London and across the capital. They are designed to provide safe, fast routes for cyclists who commute and are painted blue to indicate where they are. Some are segregated from the road but some may be on the main carriageway. **Quietways** link key destinations in the capital but utilise side streets, waterways and parks instead of busy roads.

The **towpaths** in north London along the Grand Union Canal and Regent's Canal, and in London's parks and other green areas, provide a traffic-free cycle path through the capital. The Grand Union canal connects Paddington to Camden and the Regent's Canal connects Camden to Islington, Mile End and Limehouse in east London. It takes about 30-40 minutes to cycle from Paddington station to Islington along the towpaths. **Pedestrians have priority** (<https://canalrivertrust.org.uk/enjoy-the-waterways/cycling/cycling-faqs>) on towpaths - slow down and respect their right of the way!

By taxi

London has two types of taxis: the famous **black cab**, and so-called **minicabs**. Black cabs are the only ones licensed to "ply for hire" (i.e. pick people up off the street), while minicabs are more accurately described as "private hire vehicles" and need to be pre-booked.

The famous **black cab** of London (not always black!) can be hailed from the kerb or found at one of the many designated taxi ranks. It is possible to book black cabs by phone, for a fee, but if you are in central London it will usually be quicker to hail one from the street. Their amber TAXI light will be on if they are available. Drivers must pass a rigorous exam of central London's streets, known as 'The Knowledge', to be licensed to drive a black cab. This means they can supposedly navigate you to almost any London street without reference to a map. They are a cheap transport option if there are five passengers as they do not charge extras, and many view them as an essential experience for any visitor to London. Black cabs charge by distance and by the minute, are non-smoking, and have a minimum charge of £3.00 (as of 2019). Tipping is not mandatory in either taxis or minicabs, despite some drivers' expectations - use your discretion. If you like the service you may tip. If the ride has been uncomfortable or unsafe, or if the driver was rude, don't. Most Londoners will simply round up to the nearest pound.

Taxis are required by law to take you wherever you choose (within Greater London) if their TAXI light is on when you hail them. However some, especially older drivers, dislike leaving the centre of town, or going south of the River Thames. A good way to combat being left at the side of the curb is to open the back door, or even get into the cab, before stating your destination.

Minicabs are normal cars which are licensed hire vehicles that you need to book by phone or at a minicab office. They generally charge a fixed fare for a journey, best agreed before you get in the car. Minicabs are usually cheaper than black cabs, although this is not necessarily the case for short journeys. Licensed minicabs display a Transport For London (TfL) Licence - usually in the front window. One of the features of the license plate is a blue version of the famous London Transport "roundel". A list of licensed minicab operators can be found at TfL Cabwise (<http://www.tfl.gov.uk/tfl/gettingaround/taxiprivatere/default.aspx>).



Classic London Cab on Old Bailey Street

TfL operate a service called Cabwise (<http://www.tfl.gov.uk/tfl/gettingaround/taxisandminicabs/taxis/default.aspx>), which will determine your location and provide three local, licensed cab numbers. If you have an iPhone or an Android smartphone, you can use the Cabwise application (search your platform's app store) or text **CAB** to 60835 (be careful - this might not work from some phones!) You can also use an app which allows you to summon a black cab to your location and will provide a map and approximate wait time for your taxi to arrive. Most railway stations will also be able to provide a list of good local cab firms (many will display this outside the station, even after the last train of the night has gone.)

Some areas in London are poorly served by black cabs, particularly late at night. This has led to illegal minicabs operating, who are just opportunistic people with a car, looking to make some "fast" money. Some of these illegal operators can be fairly aggressive in their attempts to find customers, and it's now barely possible to walk late at night through any part of London with a modicum of night-life without being approached. If you've booked a "licensed" minicab to collect you from a venue, the driver or operator should be able to give you additional details, (an example being the phone-number you booked them from), to confirm they are legitimate. If you book by mobile phone, many minicab firms will send you a text with a brief description of the vehicle and its registration number.

You should **avoid** minicabs touting for business off the street and either take a black cab, book a licensed minicab by telephone, or take a night bus. Not only is it 'illegal' for unlicensed minicabs to ply for trade on the street, these illegal cabs are also regularly unsafe, with a risk of robbery or assault a possibility, given that the operators of such illegal minicabs are in no way checked or vetted for past offences.

Always remember: **if it's not licensed and it's not pre-booked, it's just a stranger's car. Never get into an un-booked minicab.**

Uber (<https://www.uber.com/cities/london>) is available in London and generally charge cheaper fares than black cabs, although higher "surge" prices are charged at times of high demand. Vehicles can only be booked via the smartphone app.

By car

Londoners who drive will normally take public transport in the centre; follow their example. Unless you have a disability, there is no good reason whatsoever to drive a car in central London. Driving in central London is a slow, frustrating, expensive and often unnecessary activity. There are many sorts of automatic enforcement cameras and it is difficult and expensive to park.

Driving outside of central London is easier, but traffic can still be an issue and most tourists won't head out that far unless they have a reason. For those with disabilities driving can be much more convenient than using public transport. If disabled and a resident of a member state of the EU then two cars can be permanently registered, for free, for the Congestion Charge.

There's a **speed limit** of 20 mph (32 km/h) on most roads inside the Central London Congestion Charge zone, and several boroughs have borough-wide 20 limits. Limits elsewhere follow UK norms; see [Driving in the United Kingdom#Speed limits](#) for details.

Congestion Charge

Driving into central London on weekdays during daylight hours incurs a hefty charge called the Congestion Charge with very few exemptions. Rental cars also attract the charge. Cameras and mobile units record and identify the number plates and registration details of all vehicles entering the charging zone with high accuracy. The **Central London Congestion Charge** (<https://www.tfl.gov.uk/modes/driving/congestion-charge>) M-F 7AM-6PM (excluding public holidays) attracts a fee of £15. Numerous payment options exist: by phone, online, at convenience stores displaying the red 'C' logo in the window, and by voucher. Failure to pay the charge by midnight the next charging day incurs a hefty automatic fine of £160 (£80 if paid within 2 weeks). There are additional charges and penalties for vehicles not meeting certain emissions standards.

Traffic

Despite the Congestion Charge, London - like most major cities - continues to experience traffic snarls. These are, of course, worse on weekdays during peak commuting hours (i.e. :30-9:30AM and 4-7PM). At these times public transport (and especially the Tube) usually offers the best alternative for speed and reduced hassle.

Parking

One good tip is, that outside advertised restricted hours (usually on a Sunday), parking on a *single* yellow line is permissible. Parking on a red line or a *double* yellow line is never permissible and heavily enforced. Find and read the parking restrictions carefully! Parking during weekdays and on Saturday can also mean considerable expense in parking fees (fees and restrictions are ignored at your extreme financial peril). Issuing fines, clamping and/or towing vehicles (without warning!) has become a veritable new industry for borough councils staffed by armies of traffic wardens.

Also watch out for marked parking bays as these *always* have restrictions. Many are "Resident Parking Only" between certain hours and you will be fined if you park during these hours without a permit. Some bays also have restrictions on how long you can park in them for and these can be confusing. If in doubt: Don't park!

If you are driving to your destination then it's safest to find a dedicated private car park nearby. These may be eye-wateringly expensive, but parking on the roads is a lottery with low odds of you winning. Two large car park operators are **NCP** (<https://www.ncp.co.uk/search/results/?keyword=london&show=carParks>) and **Q-Park** (<https://www.q-park.co.uk/en-gb/>).

Motorcycles and scooters

Motorcycles and scooters are fairly common in London as they can pass stationary cars, can usually be parked for free, and are exempt from the Congestion Charge. Scooters and bikes with automatic transmission are much more preferable - a manually-gear racing bike is completely impractical unless you have excellent clutch control (although it has to be said you will see plenty of them being ridden aggressively by motorcycle couriers and locals as it can be the fastest way to get around!) Likewise to bicycles, car drivers can sometimes show disregard to anyone on two wheels and larger vehicles have an unwritten priority so take care when crossing junctions. Helmets are mandatory. Parking for bikes is usually free - there are designated motorcycle-parking areas on some side-streets and some multi-level car parks will have bike parking on the ground level.

By boat

London is now promoting a network of river bus and pleasure cruise services along the River Thames from Hampton Court in the west to Woolwich Arsenal in the east. London River Services (<http://tfl.gov.uk/river>) (part of Transport for London) manages regular commuter boats and a network of piers all along the river and publishes timetables and river maps (<https://tfl.gov.uk/maps/river?intcmp=29736>) similar to the famous Tube map. While boat travel may be slower and a little more expensive than Tube travel, it offers an extremely pleasant way to cross the city with unrivalled views of the London skyline. Sailing under Tower Bridge is an unforgettable experience.



Regent's Canal



Boats are operated by private companies and they have a separate ticketing system from the rest of London transport; however if you have a Travelcard you get a 33% discount on most boat tickets. Many boat operators offer their own one-day ticket - ask at the pier kiosks. Generally, tickets from one boat company are not valid on other operators' services. Oyster cards can be used as payment for the 'Clipper'-styled commuter services but not for tour boats.

All the central London sights in Westminster and the South Bank tourist attractions are easily accessible by boat as are:



The view from Greenwich Observatory  which is easily reached by boat services plying the Thames

▪ Hampton Court Palace ▪ Greenwich ▪ Shakespeare's Globe ▪ Tate Galleries	▪ London Dungeon ▪ London Eye ▪ Tower of London	▪ Tower Bridge ▪ St. Katharine Docks ▪ Millennium Dome/The O2	▪ Ham House ▪ Kew Gardens ▪ HMS Belfast
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Consider a trip along an old Victorian canal through the leafy suburbs of North London. The London Waterbus Company (<http://www.londonwaterbus.com/>) runs scheduled services (more in summer, fewer in winter) from Little Venice to Camden Lock with a stop at the London Zoo (pick up only). The 45-minute trip along Regent's Canal is a delightful way to travel.

By skate

Inline skating on roads and pavements (sidewalks) is completely legal, except in the "square-mile" of the City of London. Roads are not the greatest but easily skateable. Central London drivers are more used to skaters than those in the outskirts.

By cable car

The **London cable car** (<https://tfl.gov.uk/modes/london-cable-car/>) (branded for sponsorship reasons as **IFS Cloud Cable Car**; formerly Emirates Air Line) is a cable car that runs across the River Thames in east London giving panoramic views of the surrounding area and beyond. It connects the Greenwich Peninsula on the south bank (near The O2) and the Royal Docks on the north bank (near the ExCeL Exhibition Centre), with the Greenwich Peninsula terminal connecting to North Greenwich Tube station on the Jubilee line and the Royal Docks terminal connecting to Royal Victoria DLR station.



The Emirates Air Line crosses the River Thames between Greenwich Peninsula and the Royal Docks. 

Although it is part of the TfL network and uses Oyster cards, the London cable car is mostly a tourist attraction for many and is therefore at its quietest during the week. It tends to be busiest when there is a large event at the ExCeL Exhibition Centre or a popular concert at The O2.

The cable car service sometimes finishes earlier than the Tube and DLR. If you are travelling to The O2 for an event that finishes late, you should have an alternative means in mind for getting back across the river.

Operating hours

Day	2 October to 31 March	1 April to 30 June	1 July to 1 October
Monday to Thursday	07:00-21:00	07:00-22:00	07:00-23:00
Friday	07:00-23:00	07:00-23:00	07:00-23:00
Saturday and Bank Holidays	08:00-23:00	08:00-23:00	08:00-23:00
Sunday	09:00-21:00	09:00-22:00	09:00-23:00

See

“I have sailed the world, beheld its wonders
From the Dardanelles to the mountains of Peru
But there's no place like London!

”

Stephen Sondheim, *Sweeney Todd*

London is a huge city, so all individual listings are in the appropriate district articles and only an overview is presented here.

Landmarks

- **Buckingham Palace.** The London residence of the King, in Westminster. Open for tours during the summer months only (in 2022 - from Jul 22 to Sep 30; tickets - <https://tickets.rct.uk/product/date>), but a must-see sight even if you don't go in. (Tube: Green Park). Changing of the Guard spans three locations: Buckingham Palace, St James's Palace and Wellington Barracks, and usually begins at 10:43 (check <https://changing-guard.com/dates-buckingham-palace.html> for details).
- **London Eye.** The world's fourth-largest observation wheel, on the South Bank of the Thames with magnificent views over London. (Tube: Waterloo)
- **Marble Arch** is a white Carrara marble monument designed by John Nash. It is located in the middle of a huge traffic island at one of the busiest intersections in central London where Oxford Street meets Park Lane in Mayfair. (Tube: Marble Arch)
- **Piccadilly Circus** is one of the most photographed sights in London. The Shaftesbury Memorial, topped by the statue of Anteros (now popularly identified as Eros), stands proudly in the middle of Piccadilly Circus while the north eastern side is dominated by a huge, iconic neon advertising hoarding. Occasionally there will be scaffolding or fencing around the Eros statue in order to protect it during times when large crowds are anticipated. (Tube: Piccadilly Circus)
- **St Paul's Cathedral**, also in the City, is Sir Christopher Wren's great accomplishment, built after the 1666 Great Fire of London - the great dome is still seated in majesty over the City. A section of the dome has such good acoustics that it forms a "Whispering Gallery". There is

London with children

London can be stressful with kids – check London with children for slightly less stressful sightseeing. However, it is a breeze with children over 7.

Transport for London Itineraries

Feeling overwhelmed? Not sure how to begin planning your trip? Transport for London have produced their own useful list of itineraries for tourists (<https://tfl.gov.uk/travel-information/visiting-london/experience-london/itineraries>). They include famous landmarks and iconic transport icons on their various public transport networks, among others.

also a viewing area that offers views of the surrounding area including the Millennium Bridge that lies nearby. (Tube: St Paul's)

- **Tower Bridge.** The iconic 19th century bridge located by the Tower of London near the City. It is decorated with high towers featuring a drawbridge. The public are allowed access to the interior of the bridge via the **Tower Bridge Exhibition**, tickets for which can be purchased online or at the bridge. (Tube: Tower Hill)
- **Tower of London.** Situated just south east of the City, is London's original royal fortress by the Thames. It is over 900 years old, contains the Crown Jewels, is guarded by Beefeaters, and is a World Heritage site. It is also considered by many to be the most haunted building in the world. If you are interested in that sort of thing it's definitely somewhere worth visiting. Sometimes there are guided ghost walks of the building. You can even have a good meal in one of the buildings on the property. (Tube: Tower Hill)
- **Trafalgar Square.** Home of Nelson's Column and the lions, and once a safe haven for London's pigeons until the introduction of hired birds of prey. The "Fourth Plinth" has featured a succession of artworks since 1999. Overlooked by the National Gallery, it's the nearest London has to a "centre", and has been pedestrianised. (Tube: Charing Cross)
- **Westminster Abbey and the Palace of Westminster,** including the **Elizabeth Tower** (the clock tower commonly known by the name of its bell, **Big Ben**) and the **Houses of Parliament**, in Westminster. The seat of the United Kingdom parliament and World Heritage site, as well as setting for royal coronations since 1066, including Queen Elizabeth II in 1953. The Palace of Westminster is open to the public only for viewing parliamentary debates, tours of the building are available in July – August when Parliament is away on summer recess. Westminster Abbey also has a restaurant and a café that both serve good food. (Tube: Westminster)
- **30 St Mary Axe or The Gherkin,** a peculiarly-shaped 180 m (590 ft) building in the City. There is no public access to the building itself but it can be viewed from the roads and small paved areas directly in front of and behind the building (https://www.google.co.uk/maps/place/Leadenhall+St,+London/@51.5146733,-0.0808881,3a,90y,118.15h,99.12t/data=!3m7!1e1!3m5!1sfni4I_YnZYhAd0Azi2W9XA!2e0!6s%2F%2Fgeo1.ggpht.com%2Fcbk%3Fpanoid%3Dfni4I_YnZYhAd0Azi2W9XA%26output%3Dthumbnail%26cb_client%3Dmaps_sv.tactile.gps%26thumb%3D2%26w%3D100%26h%3D80%26yaw%3D196.42006%26pitch%3D0!7i13312!8i6656!4m2!3m1!1s0x4876034d6b89e435:0x8790f1ed372227bc). Security guards can be overzealous in this area and you may be asked to move on or stop taking photographs if you are doing so (although this may seem overbearing, it is private land and they can ask you to leave if they wish). Commanding views of this building can also be obtained from public roads near the site such as Leadenhall Street (<https://www.google.co.uk/maps/@51.5135079,-0.0816176,3a,75y,58.75h,108.47t/data=!3m6!1e1!3m4!1sKu4DIQkuq>



Piccadilly Circus



St Paul's Cathedral



Tower Bridge from South Bank



xvUG_7wldnLJw!2e0!7i13312!8i6656). Of minor interest to history fans is an inscription on Bury Street dedicated to a young Roman girl who was found buried here by archaeologists in 1995 (<http://www.londonremembers.com/memorials/roman-girl>). Her remains were moved to the Museum of London while the Gherkin was being constructed, and were reburied in 2007 at the original site. (Tube: Aldgate)

- **The Shard.** A futuristic triangular skyscraper in South Bank that dominates the London skyline and is the tallest building in the UK. There is a viewing deck on the 72nd floor that is open to the public, tickets for which must be booked via the website. There are also restaurants and the expensive luxury hotel Shangri-La (<http://www.shangri-la.com/london/shangri-la/about/>) on the lower floors. (Tube: London Bridge)
- **The Walkie-Talkie / 20 Fenchurch Street**, although it has been voted as one of London's ugliest skyscrapers, has a large rooftop garden which affords great views over the Thames and south side of the river. This garden is free to visit, however, it is necessary to book (<http://skygarden.london/booking>) well in advance due to high demand, especially in the summer months. (Tube: Monument)

Museums and galleries

Central London hosts an outstanding collection of world-class museums and galleries, several of truly iconic status.

Even better, London is unique among global capitals in that the majority of the museums have no entrance charges, allowing visitors to make multiple visits with ease. Special or temporary exhibitions usually attract an admission charge.

London museums and galleries with no general admission charge (free entry!) include:

- British Museum (Tube: Holborn)—a treasure trove of world cultures from across the ages, on par with the Paris Louvre and New York's Metropolitan Museum
- National Gallery (Tube: Charing Cross)—houses the national collection of paintings in the Western European tradition from the 13th to the 19th centuries
- National Portrait Gallery (Tube: Charing Cross)
- Victoria and Albert Museum (Tube: South Kensington)
- Natural History Museum (Tube: South Kensington)
- Science Museum (Tube: South Kensington)
- Tate Modern (Tube: Southwark, Blackfriars)
- Tate Britain (Tube: Pimlico)
- Wallace Collection (Tube: Marble Arch)

Aside from these world famous establishments, there is an almost unbelievable number of minor museums in London covering a very diverse range of subjects. The British Government lists over 240 genuine museums in the city. A few notable examples:

- London Transport Museum (Tube: Covent Garden)
- Museum of London (Tube: Barbican or St. Paul's)



Natural History Museum, dubbed the 'cathedral of nature' 

- Museum of London Docklands (DLR: West India Quay)
- The Royal Museums Greenwich: (DLR: Cutty Sark)
 - Royal Observatory
 - National Maritime Museum
 - Cutty Sark

Parks

The "green lungs" of London are the **many parks**, great and small, scattered throughout the city including Hyde Park, St James Park and Regent's Park. Most of the larger parks have their origins in royal estates and hunting grounds and are still owned by the Crown, despite their public access.



St James's Park in central London



- Hyde Park and adjoining Kensington Gardens make up a huge open space in central London and are very popular for picnics. Within Kensington Gardens, the Diana, Princess of Wales, Memorial Playground is a free playground for young children featuring a huge wood pirate ship. (Tube: High Street Kensington, Marble Arch, Green Park or Hyde Park Corner)
- Regent's Park is a wonderful open park in the northern part of central London. On the northern edge is London Zoo. (Tube: Camden Town, Regent's Park)
- St James's Park has charming and romantic gardens ideal for picnics and for strolling around. St. James's Park is situated between Buckingham Palace on the west and Horse Guards Parade on the east.
- Hampstead Heath is a huge open green space in north London. It's not a tended park as such and is remarkably wild for a metropolitan city location. The views from the Parliament Hill area of the heath overlooking the city skyline are quite stunning. (Tube: Hampstead, Overground: Hampstead Heath, Gospel Oak)
- Battersea Park is a public park in the London Borough of Wandsworth, on the south bank of the Thames, and contains a Japanese pagoda.
- Richmond Park is a huge green space, with a thriving deer population. Excellent place for cycling. (Tube: Richmond then Bus 65 or 371)
- Bushy Park, near to Hampton Court Palace, is the second-largest park in London. More low-key than its larger cousin, Richmond Park, it too has a large deer population. Bushy Park contains numerous ponds, bridleways, two allotments, and at its northern edge, the National Physical Laboratory.
- Holland Park is a public park in the Royal Borough of Kensington and Chelsea, in west London. It covers about 22 hectares and contains two Japanese gardens - the Kyoto Garden (1991) and Fukushima Memorial Garden (2012), a youth hostel, a children's playground, squirrels and peacocks. The closest Tube station is Holland Park on the Central line.

Itineraries

- London South Bank Walk
- Walk the London Wall
- For a selection of walks across London, look at London on foot.

Blue Plaques

English Heritage runs the Blue Plaques (<https://www.english-heritage.org.uk/visit/blue-plaques/>) programme in London. Blue Plaques celebrate great figures of the past and the buildings that they inhabited. These are among the most familiar features of the capital's streetscape and adorn the façades of buildings across the city. Since the first plaque was erected in 1867, the number has grown steadily and there are now more than 800. Recipients are as diverse as Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, Sigmund Freud, Charles de Gaulle, Jimi Hendrix and Karl Marx. Look out for these around the city.



One of more than 800 Blue Plaques throughout London 

London Pass

Whereas some London museums offer free entry, some other top London attractions are ridiculously expensive. For example, entry to Westminster Abbey costs £20 per person (adult), and entry to the Tower is £21.50 per adult if bought online (2017). These prices can be sometimes mitigated by a purchase of London Pass, which needs to be done at the [London Pass website](http://www.londonpass.com) (<http://www.londonpass.com>). The pass comes in several varieties and gives access to over 60 attractions, including both Westminster Abbey and the Tower. For example, a day pass costs £62 for an adult (2017). The best strategy, if one wants to visit several expensive high-profile attractions, is to buy a day pass and to try visiting all of them in the same day. This requires some advanced planning and will not give you much time at each place you visit - for example, it can take an hour on public transport to travel between the Tower of London and London Zoo.

Suburbs

London boasts a variety of suburbs beyond the crowded city centre in its metropolitan area. These include highlights of unique local culture, green spaces, and historic charm in key suburban areas.

Do

London is a huge city, so all individual listings are in the appropriate [district](#) articles. To make the most of the city's tremendous cultural offerings (performing arts, museums, exhibitions, clubs, eateries and numerous others), visitors will do well to pick up a copy of a cultural magazine like *Time Out London* (available at most corner shops and newsagents) which gives detailed information and critiques on what's around town including show times and current attractions. The [Time Out London website](https://www.timeout.com/london) (<https://www.timeout.com/london>) also has major shows listed. There is also apps available, although the print version tends to be more detailed.

Live music

London is one of the best cities in the world for concerts, spanning from new musical trends to well-known bands. Between huge concert facilities and small pubs, there are hundreds of venues that organise and promote live music every week. Many concerts, especially in smaller or less known places are free, so there is plenty of choice even for tourists on a budget.

London has long been a launchpad for alternative movements, from the mods of the 1960s, punks of the 70s, new romantics of the 80s, the Britpop scene of the 90s, and the indie rock and rock movements in the 21st century. It has one of the world's most lively live music scenes: any band heading a British, European or World tour will play London, not to mention the local talent. London's music scene is incredibly diverse, covering all genres of music from electro-jazz to death-metal, and all sizes of bands, from the U2s and Rolling Stones of the world to bands that disband after their first gig. This diversity is reflected in prices. As a rough guide: £40 and up for 'top 40' bands in arena-sized venues, £20 and up for established bands in mid-sized venues, £10 or more for up-and-coming bands and club nights in smaller venues, £5 and up for new bands in bars and pubs (as of 2024). Wigmore Hall offers classical music concerts in an intimate setting. The usual fare is between £18 and £60 but £5 tickets are available for most concerts for those aged under 35.

London has hundreds of venues spread out over the city and the best way to know what's going on where is to browse online ticket agencies, *Music Magazine's* gig directories and bands' social media pages. A few areas which have higher concentrations of pubs and venues than others. Kilburn in North West London has long been known as an Irish area; though their numbers have somewhat declined, a visit to a local pub will show their influence endures.

Theatre

The **West End**, especially the areas concentrated around Leicester Square, Covent Garden, Shaftesbury Avenue and Haymarket, is one of the world's premier destinations for theatre, including musical theatre. In the centre of Leicester Square there is an official half-price **TKTS** booth. Be wary of other ticket offices -including those claiming to be the "Official Half-Price Ticket Office" - as these may have higher prices, and have been known to sell fake tickets. For up-to-date listings see the weekly magazine *Time Out* (<http://timeout.com/london>) or check the Official London Theatre (http://officiallondontheatre.co.uk/london_shows/) site.



Palace Theatre



The South Bank is another area well known for world class theatre, and is home to the National Theatre and the **Globe Theatre**, the latter of which is London's only thatched building and an attraction in itself. Each Globe performance has over 700 £5 tickets.

London's theatre scene outside of these two main districts is known as "the Fringe". Several of the larger and more established fringe theatres are an excellent way to see top quality productions of plays that may move to the West End, but at lower than West End prices. **The Royal Court** theatre specialises in new work by innovative writers from the UK and around the

world. The **Menier Chocolate Factory** has done spectacularly well with revivals of musicals. **The Lyric Theatre**, Hammersmith, offers a mix of modern interpretations of Shakespeare, musicals, and plays serving the Asian and Afro-Caribbean populations of West London.

Other things to do

- Take a walk through London's **Royal Parks**. A good walk would start at Paddington station, and head through Kensington Gardens, Hyde Park, Green Park (passing Buckingham Palace) and St James's Park before crossing Trafalgar Square and the River Thames to the South Bank and Waterloo station. At a strolling pace this walk would take half a day, with plenty of places to stop, sit, drink, and eat en route.
- **Watch a film:** As well as the world-famous blockbuster cinemas in the West End, London has a large number of superb art house cinemas. In the summer months, there are often outdoor screenings at various venues, such as Somerset House and in some of the large parks.
- **Watch football:** London has over a dozen professional football clubs, plus **Wembley Stadium**, the national stadium of England, hosting internationals (including World Cup and European Championships qualifiers) and the finals of club competitions, notably the FA Cup and the League Cup. As of 2024, London has six clubs in the Premier League, the top tier of English football: Arsenal, Chelsea, Crystal Palace, Brentford, Tottenham Hotspur (Spurs), Fulham, and West Ham United. In the second tier, the Championship, are Millwall and Queens Park Rangers (QPR). In the third tier, League One, are Charlton Athletic and Leyton Orient; and in the fourth tier, League Two, are AFC Wimbledon and Sutton United. Other clubs slug it out in the lower leagues, semi-professional going on amateur. International and top club matches need booking in advance, and at clubs like Arsenal and Chelsea, it's nearly impossible to get regular tickets without some sort of club membership, though much more expensive corporate hospitality tickets are usually available. Purchasing tickets through a shady third party website or a scalper is best avoided as those tickets are very unlikely to be valid. However, at smaller clubs you can just turn up and pay at the gate. At bottom-end clubs there's actually a risk that you might be begged to strip off and take the field to make up an eleven. Hackney & Walthamstow marshes have football teams and playing fields the way Xanadu had caverns measureless to man, with a thin drizzle blowing in off a sunless sea.
- **Watch rugby union**, 15-a-side. Internationals are played at **Twickenham** west of the city - the Six Nations games are likely to sell out. Three London teams play in the Premiership, the top tier of club rugby in England: Harlequins, London Irish and Saracens. You'll see famous international players in these club fixtures.
- **Watch tennis at Wimbledon:** Wimbledon is the oldest tennis tournament in the world and is widely considered the most prestigious. Naturally it is a regular feature on the tennis calendar. London goes "tennis crazy" for two weeks when the competition commences in late June and early July. One of the greatest traditions of this event is to eat strawberries and cream with sugar. (Tube: Southfields)
- **Watch cricket** at the Oval (Lambeth) or Lord's (St Johns). Both host One-Day and Test matches (i.e. internationals, lasting up to 5 days). Watch important events like Ashes and India and South Africa Tours to London. Oval and Lord's are also the home grounds for Oval Invincibles and London Spirit respectively in the Hundred. Lord's is also the home ground for Middlesex in the County Championship and One Day Cup.
- **London Open House Weekend:** Explore many of the city's most interesting buildings during the London Open House Weekend (<http://openhouse.org.uk>), usually held on the third



Changing the Guard at Buckingham Palace 

weekend of September. During this single weekend, several hundred buildings which are not normally open to the public are opened up. See website for details of buildings opening in any given year. Some buildings have to be booked in advance; book early for the popular ones.

- **Winter skating.** During the winter months multiple outdoor ice rinks pop up across London. Considered by some to be somewhat overpriced and overcrowded, they nonetheless have multiplied, easing congestion and increasing competition. Most charge from £10-12 (adults) for an hour on the ice, including skate hire. See the district articles for the City of London, East End and Leicester Square.
- **Summer skating.** In summer (and also in winter, for the more dedicated) there is also a thriving roller skating (on inline and traditional "quad" skates) scene in London, catering to many disciplines including street hockey, freestyle slalom, dance, general recreational skating (including three weekly marshalled group street skates) and speed skating. This mostly centres around Hyde Park (on the Serpentine Road) and Kensington Gardens (by the Albert Memorial). See the district articles for Mayfair-Marylebone and South West London.
- **Bus and river tours:** If you don't feel like splashing out on one of the commercial bus tours, you can make your own bus tour by buying an **Oyster** card and spending some time riding around London on the top deck of standard London buses. You don't get the open air or the commentary, but the views are very similar. You will likely get lost but that is half the fun; if that worries you then go for a commercial tour, which will give you a 24-hour ticket to use the company's buses to see the essential sites of London and a boat tour on the Thames (with the same ticket) provides a river tour of some of metropolitan London. Commercial tours are also the only remaining way to ride a vintage red **rotemaster bus** through the city streets.
- **Photography.** Buildings such as museums, churches and art galleries will display their own guidelines clearly. In many public buildings the use of tripods and flash are not permitted.
- **Hidden London (<https://www.ltmuseum.co.uk/whats-on/hidden-london>).** A series of tours run by the London Transport Museum exploring the hidden depths of the Underground, including abandoned stations and tunnels; plus there are visits to TfL's famous art deco headquarters (55 Broadway) and "access all areas" inside looks at operational stations such as Charing Cross and Euston. Demand is high for what is quite a restricted annual programme, and you can purchase a maximum of four tickets per tour. Adults: £41.50, concession: £36.50. This ticket includes a day pass to the LT Museum, to be used within a month of the event date, and gives you a 10% discount on all merchandise bought at the museum shop or online within the same period.
- **NFL International Series.** NFL (American Football) games held in Wembley and Twickenham Stadiums. Usually held on Sunday evenings or afternoons between October and December of each year.

Learn

Learn English

London is a natural place to learn and improve spoken and written English. There are a huge range of options, from informal language exchange services to evening classes and formal language schools. There are unaccredited schools charging hefty fees and offering qualifications that are viewed as worthless. If choosing a course from a privately-run school or college, it is important to ensure the institution is accredited by the British Council.

Universities in London

London attracts more students from overseas than any other city in the world and is home to a huge variety of academic institutions. Its universities include some of the oldest and most prestigious in the world. The University of London (<http://www.london.ac.uk/>) is a federal university system with many constituent colleges,

Some links to British Council accredited schools:

- **Linguaenglish London** (<http://www.linguaenglish.com/uk/english-school.php?id=1>). Lingua London is a family-run English language school and has been teaching English only courses in London for over 10 years.
- **Rose of York** (<http://www.roseofyork.com>), ☎ +44 20 7580-9888, hello@roseofyork.com (mailto:hello@roseofyork.com). Rose of York has been teaching English language courses for over 28 years and they offer full-time, intensive or part-time English courses (updated Dec 2017 |)

Work

London is one of the world's leading financial centres and so professional services is the main area of employment. It is best to check with recruiters and staffing agencies.

London is hugely popular as a working holiday destination - work in bars and the hospitality industry is relatively easy to find.

Wages are generally higher in London than the rest of the UK, in part due to the addition of London weighting, although the cost of living is higher still.

Buy

Money

London is among the worst places to exchange money. Included fees (in the exchange rate) of up to 50% are not uncommon. Do not get fooled by the "no commission" claim that many bureaux de change make. This is a lie because the exchange rates are so bad that the exchange is very costly. So, how do you identify a decent exchange rate? Basically, the spread between the buy and sell rate tells you what is the fee (divided by 2, actually)—anything above 10% is a rip-off, 5% is good. You are better off withdrawing money from ATMs here. *Never* attempt to change money on either Leicester Square or Tottenham Court Road; rates there can be misrepresented.

though for all practical purposes each constituent college operates as a separate university. **London School of Economics and Political Science** (<http://lse.ac.uk>) is located on the boundary of Covent Garden and Holborn in Westminster. The School offers a well-regarded lecture programme that is open to the public. Event schedule and ticket information available from the LSE website. **University College London** (<http://ucl.ac.uk>) academic research is cited more than any other university in the UK, and its courses are regarded as among the best in Britain. The campus is located just north of the British Museum in the literary area of Bloomsbury. **Imperial College London** (<http://www3.imperial.ac.uk/>) is the UK's leading university specialising in science, engineering, business and medicine. The campus is in South Kensington. Others include **King's College London** (<http://www.kcl.ac.uk/k/index.aspx>), **School of Oriental and African Studies** (<http://www.soas.ac.uk/>) (SOAS), **Queen Mary, University of London** (<http://qmul.ac.uk/>), **London Business School** (<http://london.edu>), **University of Middlesex** (<https://www.mdx.ac.uk/>) and the **University of Westminster** (<http://www.westminster.ac.uk/>)

Shopping

London has a justified reputation for being one of the world's most expensive cities. But if you do your homework beforehand, there are ways to limit the damage, and prices for basic items are in general not as exorbitant as in the Nordic countries or Switzerland.

London is one of the world's most fashion-conscious cities: it has an abundance of clothing shops from the flagship stores of Oxford Street to the tiny boutiques of Brick Lane.

Though not particularly known for bargain shopping, nearly anything you could possibly want to buy is available in London. During major sales, such as the annual Boxing Day sale after Christmas, and Black Friday in late November (an event imported from the U.S.), prices for some items are lowered by up to 70%, meaning that it is possible to find bargains for genuine luxury-branded goods if you are there at the right time. Outside of major brands and retailers, you may want to check if an item has actually ever sold at the claimed full price.

In Central London, the main shopping district is the West End (Bond Street, Covent Garden, Oxford Street and Regent Street). On Thursdays many West End stores close later than normal (7-8PM).



Harrods



- **Oxford Street.** Main shopping street, home to flagship branches of all the major British high street retailers in one go including Selfridges (<http://selfridges.co.uk/>), John Lewis (<https://johnlewis.com>) (includes a food hall), Marks & Spencer (<http://marksandspencer.com>) and other department stores. It is best to shop here in the morning as the street becomes increasingly busy during the day. (Tube: Oxford Circus)
- **Regent Street** (between Oxford Circus and Piccadilly Circus). Includes such gems as Hamleys, considered to be London's flagship toy store spread out on seven levels, the iconic luxury department store Liberty (<https://www.libertylondon.com/>), and the London Apple Store. (Tube: Oxford Circus, Piccadilly Circus)
- **Bond Street.** Some of the world's most luxurious designer stores such as Cartier, D&G, Jimmy Choo, Louis Vuitton and Versace. (Tube: Bond Street)
- **Tottenham Court Road.** Contains some of the world's most luxurious designer interior stores such as Heals. (Tube: Tottenham Court Road, Goodge Street)
- **Covent Garden.** Fashionable area home to quaint outlets and relatively expensive designer stores. Around Seven Dials, chains include Adidas Originals, All Saints, Carhartt, Fred Perry, G Star Raw and Stussy. For shoes, head for Neal Street. Also found here is the London Transport Museum whose gift shop has some of the best souvenirs in the city (old maps, vintage Tube posters, etc.) London's second Apple Store is located here as well. (Tube: Covent Garden)
- **Charing Cross Road** (near Covent Garden). Traditionally a book lover's haven, it still has the giant general bookstore Foyles, and a few specialist and antiquarian shops survive south of Cambridge Circus and on the side streets to the east. (Tube: Tottenham Court Road, Leicester Square, or Charing Cross)
- **Piccadilly** (near Piccadilly Circus). Home to the luxury department store Fortnum & Mason (<https://www.fortnumandmason.com/>).

- **Denmark Street** (at the north end of Charing Cross Road near Tottenham Court Road station). Also known as Tin-Pan Alley, this is a music lover's paradise with an amazing array of music shops, bars and clubs in one short street. (Tube: Tottenham Court Road)
- **Soho**. Offers alternative music and clothes. Now home to Chappell of Bond Street's historic music shop. (Tube: Oxford Circus)
- **Camden Town**. Alternative clothing and other alternative shopping, popular with teenagers and young adults. Has the headquarters for Cyberdog - a large shop which sells clothing and accessories for the club and rave scene. Camden Lock Market is also worth a visit to see independent artists plying their wares. (Tube: Camden Town)
- **Chelsea**. The King's Road is noted for fashion, homeware and children's clothing. On Wednesday many stores close late. (Tube: South Kensington)
- **Knightsbridge**. Department stores include the world-famous Harrods (<http://harrods.com/>) (includes a food hall) and Harvey Nichols (<http://www.harveynichols.com/>). On Wednesday many stores close late. (Tube: Knightsbridge)
- **Beauchamp Place**. Shop where royalty and celebrities shop! One of the world's most unique and famous streets. It is known as one of London's most fashionable and distinctive streets, housing some of the best known names in London fashion, interspersed with trendy restaurants, jewellers and speciality shops including Fortuny (<http://fortuneshop.com>). (Tube: Knightsbridge)
- **Westminster**. Some of the world's most famous shirts are made on Jermyn Street. Savile Row is home to some of the world's best men's bespoke tailors including Henry Poole, Gieves & Hawkes, H. Huntsman & Sons, and Dege & Skinner. (Tube: Westminster)
- **Westfield London** in Shepherd's Bush is one of the two largest shopping mall complexes in Greater London. It is served by the London Overground and the Underground. It is easiest to get here via public transport, but there is reasonable car parking space available. (Tube: Shepherd's Bush)
- **Westfield Stratford City** in Stratford is a large shopping mall complex located on the edge of the Queen Elizabeth Olympic Park. There is ample car parking and you can also park here to access the park. This Westfield is easier to access by car due to its close proximity to the A12 road. (Tube/DLR: Stratford)

Markets

Borough Market is a great (if expensive) food market (<http://boroughmarket.org.uk/>), offering fruit, vegetables, cheese, bread, meat, fish, and so on, much of it organic. The market opens Th-Sa. Many stalls offer freshly made fast food on the spot for lunch; from ostrich burgers to falafel, most tastes are catered for. (Tube: London Bridge)

Old Spitalfields Market is an excellent market for clothes from up-and-coming designers, records, housewares, food, and all things trendy. (Tube: Liverpool Street)

Also be sure to check out Brick Lane Market, Greenwich Market and Portobello Road Market.

Tax-free

Tax-free shops in airports are not strong in variety, prices are equal to London, and they close rather early as well. Shop listings at airport web sites can help to plan your tax-free (vs traditional) shopping. In the evening allow an extra half hour as closing hours are not always strictly respected.

Nevertheless, tax-free (at the airport) does not mean cheaper. Prices are determined by the shop owner at their own discretion, and due to the large crowds, high shop rents, and free marketing there is no real reason why anyone should offer prices below average. Also, often goods sold here have different sizes than in regular stores, making it harder to compare. Furthermore, tax-free shops mostly only offer expensive brands and no cheap non-brand stuff, like simple sun glasses. Either way, you are better off doing your shopping somewhere else.

Nevertheless, a different matter is **tax reclaim**. Many big department stores in central London have an information booth where they can give you the paperwork needed to reclaim tax on purchases made at the store when you get to the airport.

Eat

For suggestions of specific restaurants have a look into the [district articles](#).

It is a huge task for a visitor to find the "right place" to eat in London – with the "right atmosphere", at the "right price" – largely because, as in any big city, there are literally thousands of venues from which to choose, ranging from fast food joints, pubs, and mainstream chains all the way up to some of the most exclusive restaurants in the world which attract the kind of clientele that don't need to ask the price. Sorting the good from the bad isn't easy, but London has something to accommodate all budgets and tastes. As London is one of the world's most multicultural cities, it is possible to find virtually every cuisine from around the world here if you look hard enough.

This page uses the following price ranges for a typical meal *for one*, including soft drink:

Budget	Below £15
Mid-range	£15-50
Splurge	£50+

Prices inevitably become inflated at venues closest to major tourist attractions - beware the so-called tourist traps. The worst tourist trap food, in the opinion of many Londoners, is served at the various steak houses (Angus Steak House, Aberdeen Steak House, etc. – they are all dotted around the West End and near the main train stations). Londoners wouldn't dream of eating here – you shouldn't either! Notorious areas for inflated menu prices trading on travellers' gullibility and lack of knowledge are the streets around the British Museum, Leicester Square and Piccadilly Circus. Even the major fast food chains charge a premium in their West End outlets, so watch out.

Smoking Ban

Smoking is illegal in all enclosed and indoor public spaces in the UK.

Pubs in the touristy areas of London are usually a poor choice for food although there are some brilliant "gastro-pubs" hidden away. In general, avoid all pubs that have graphic-designed and printed menus. Look around you – see any locals tucking in? No? Then you shouldn't either. The other rule to follow when avoiding poor food is the same as in any other part of Europe – is the menu available in multiple languages? If yes, then start running!

In the suburbs, the cost of eating out is reduced drastically. Particularly in large ethnic communities, there is a competitive market which stands to benefit the consumer. In East London for example, the vast number of chicken shops means that a deal for 2 pieces of chicken, chips (fries) and a drink shouldn't cost you much especially on **Brick Lane**. Brick Lane is also

known for being home to London's version of the **beigel** (spelt "bagel" in the United States and Canada, but pronounced the same way), with **Brick Lane Beigel Bake** and **Britain's First & Best Beigel Shop** being among the sole remnants of what was once a thriving Jewish community in the neighbourhood. Both shops are also known for their **salt beef**, London's version of Jewish-style cured meats, and a popular filling in their beigel sandwiches. Another good (and cheap) lunch option is a chicken or lamb doner (gyro) at many outlets throughout the city, though meat quality is often poor.

For more authentic Cockney food, try **pie and mash**, which originates from the working-class in the East End. Usually minced beef and cold water pastry pie served with mashed potato, mushy peas and "liquor" gravy, it tastes a lot better than it sounds. Some of the best pie houses are **M. Manze** in Peckham or **F. Cooke** in Hackney Broadway Market. Water Souchet and London Particular (green-pea and ham) are classic Cockney soups, though hard to find on menus. For those game, **jellied eels**, pickled-cockles and whelks are all traditional London seafood. It's people's experiences in these kind of places that gives Britain a bad name for food!

The South Bank's **Borough Market** offers wholesale produce as well as individual stalls that sell small bites and drinks for a casual and cheap meal. **Kappacasein Dairy** has a popular stand in the market famous for their grilled cheese which has earned the praise of Giada De Laurentiis and Ruth Reichl.

Of course, the quintessential British dish **fish and chips** is widely available in London, but the standards can be pretty disappointing in the tourist trap pubs. The best-rated fish and chips shops in London are generally located in the suburbs, away from all the tourist fare in central London.

For hamburgers, local chain **Burger & Lobster** (<https://www.burgerandlobster.com/>) is an excellent choice for gourmet burgers.

Tipping may also be different than what you're used to. All meals include the 20% VAT tax and some places include a service fee (10–12%). The general rule is to leave a tip for table service, unless there's already a service charge added or unless the service has been notably poor. The amount tipped is generally in the region of 10%, but if there's a figure between 10–15% which would leave the bill at a conveniently round total, many would consider it polite to tip this amount. Tipping for counter service, or any other form of service, is unusual - but some choose to do so if a tips container is provided.

Restaurant streets

While central London is full of restaurants and cafes, there are some areas where the majority of diners are Londoners, rather than tourists, and in general you will get a much more pleasant, better value, and less crowded eating experience than you will find in the West End. These places



Sparkenhoe Blue cheese from
Borough Market



are best visited in the evenings.

- **Clapham Junction** is not just a train station, but also home to many good restaurants and bars, in particular on Lavender Hill and Battersea Rise. (Overground: Clapham Junction)
- **Drummond Street** in the Euston area has a fine mix of Indian restaurants - a short walk from Euston railway station. (Tube: Euston)
- **High Street Croydon** Croydon is derided by most Londoners, however this suburban gem of a road has at least 30 decent restaurants, including three Argentinians, a South African curryhouse, a couple of fancy modern European brasseries, and just about every other type of cuisine you can think of. (Overground: East Croydon)
- **Kings Street** extends on to Chiswick High Road from Hammersmith Tube Station and is one long road of a choice of restaurants at very reasonable prices, some bargain mentions are the Thai restaurants offering two-course lunch. Nearby Shepherds Bush is about a 15 minute walk and is alive with bars and pubs in the evening. (Tube: Hammersmith)
- **Lordship Lane** in East Dulwich provides a good selection of European restaurants and a few award winning gastropubs. (train: East Dulwich)
- **Upper Street** in Islington has dozens of excellent restaurants, popular with young professionals. (Tube: Highbury & Islington, Angel).
- **Wardour Street**, in Soho, is full of nice cafes and restaurants. (Tube: Piccadilly Circus)

Restaurant areas

As one of the world's most cosmopolitan cities, you can find restaurants serving food cuisine from nearly every country, some of it as good as, if not better than in the countries of origin. Indian food in London is especially famous and there is hardly a district without at least one notable Indian restaurant. London also has excellent options for Chinese, in particular Cantonese food; local chain **Royal China** (<https://www.royalchinagroup.co.uk/>) is an excellent option if you are looking for high-end fine dining dim sum.

If you are looking for other particular regional foods these tend to be clustered in certain areas and *some* examples are:

- Brick Lane in the East End is famous for Bangladeshi curries. (Overground: Shoreditch High Street)
- Brixton for African/Caribbean. (Tube: Brixton)
- Chinatown just off Leicester Square for Chinese. (Tube: Leicester Square, Piccadilly Circus)
- Edgware Road in Marylebone and Paddington is popular for Middle Eastern cuisine. (Tube: Edgware Road, Paddington)
- Drummond Street (just behind Euston railway station in the London/Camden district) has lots of vegetarian restaurants – mostly Indian. (Tube: Euston)
- Finsbury Park and Green Lanes, for Greek, Turkish, and Cypriot. (Tube: Finsbury Park/Manor House; Overground: Harringay Green Lanes)
- Golders Green for Jewish fare. (Tube: Golders Green)
- Kingsland Road for good cheap Vietnamese.
- Tooting, East Ham, Wembley and Southall for authentic and cheap Indian eateries including South Indian restaurants serving hot pongal, dosas, idlis and other South Indian "tiffin" items.
- Bayswater for Chinese, including the famous Four Seasons roast duck. (Tube: Bayswater, Queensway)
- Lambeth between the South Bank and Brixton for Portuguese, Brazilian and diverse Latin American restaurants. (Tube: Kennington, Stockwell, Vauxhall)

Other nationalities are equally represented and randomly dotted all over London. It is usually wisest to eat in restaurants on main thoroughfares rather than on quiet backstreets.

Fast food and chains

Like other capitals in the world, London has the usual array of fast food outlets. Sandwich shops are the most popular places to buy lunch, and there are a lot of places to choose from including the ubiquitous Pret a Manger. Some Italian-style sandwich shops have a very good reputation and you can identify them easily by looking at the long queues at lunchtime. If all else fails, central London has lots of mini-supermarkets operated by the big British supermarket chains (e.g., Sainsbury's, Tesco) where you can pick up a pre-packed sandwich.

Fast food with an Asian flair is easy to find throughout the city, with lots of Busaba Eathai, Wagamama, and Yo! Sushi locations throughout the city. Nando's, a popular pseudo-Portuguese restaurant chain, has spicy peri-peri style grilled chicken. For burgers, GBK (Gourmet Burger Kitchen) has been joined by other franchises such as Byron and Haché.

Vegetarian and vegan

London has plenty of vegetarian and vegan restaurants many of them championing organic foodstuffs, and a quick search in Google will produce plenty of ideas, so you never have to see a piece of cooked meat all week. Hackney, Dalston, Islington, Soho, Peckham and Brixton are particular vegan hotspots.

If you are dining with carnivorous friends most restaurants will cater for vegetarians and will have at least a couple of dishes on the menu. Indian/Bangladeshi restaurants are generally fruitful, as they have plenty of traditional dishes. Good Indian/Bangladeshi options can be found in the Brick Lane area of Spitalfields or further afield in East Ham, Tooting Broadway, and Southall. These also tend to be very cheap eats with authentically prepared dishes with a true local ambience. There are also many vegetarian Thai buffet places where you can eat fake meat in tooth-achingly sweet sauces. These can be found on Greek Street and Old Compton Street in Soho and Islington High Street.

Mildred's is a great veggie chain with a handful of locations around London. If you're interested in vegan versions of classic British dishes, try "fish" and chips from Sutton and Sons in Hackney, and various cafes offer veggie interpretations of a full English breakfast.

Religious

Due to the mix of cultures and religions, many London restaurants cater well for religious dietary requirements. The most common signs are for Halal and Kosher meat, from burger joints to nice restaurants. There are lots of Halal restaurants and shops all over London including Whitechapel Rd and Brick Lane in the East End, Bayswater, Edgware Rd and Paddington and in many parts of north London. There are plenty of Kosher restaurants in Golders Green, Edgware and Stamford Hill along with some central delis such as on Charing Cross Road.

Convenience stores and supermarkets

Convenience stores such as Tesco Express, Sainsbury's Central/Local, Budgens, Costcutter, SPAR, Co-op, and privately-run "corner shops" will sell pre-made sandwiches, snacks, alcohol, cigarettes, drinks, etc. Most are open from 5AM–11PM although some, such as Tesco Express or convenience stores located at petrol stations, may open 24 hours (some will stop selling alcohol after a certain time). Whistlestop convenience stores, usually found in or around train stations, are notoriously overpriced and should be avoided.

If using a petrol station convenience store late at night (i.e. after 11PM) the store will be locked and you should order and pay through the external service window.

Supermarkets

Although Tesco, Sainsbury's and other supermarkets run smaller stores in central London, full-size superstores, including Morrisons and ASDA, are rare in the city centre – with the exception of the Sainsbury's in Pimlico – and you will usually have to take a 15- to 20-minute Tube ride to reach one.

Marks & Spencer (<https://www.marksandspencer.com/>), an upmarket retailer, also operate food halls branded as "Simply Food". They can be found across central London (<https://www.marksandspencer.com/s/store-listing>). The smaller stores, such as those found in train stations, tend to focus mostly on ready-to-eat food such as sandwiches, drinks, snacks, and also essentials such as bread and milk.

Drink

London is home to a great many pubs, bars and nightclubs. The online city guide *View London* (<http://www.viewlondon.co.uk/>) and the weekly magazine *Time Out* (<http://www.timeout.com/london>) tell what's going in London's night life, as well as cultural events in general.

Pubs and bars

London is an expensive place and your drink will cost more than its equivalent elsewhere in the United Kingdom. Expect to pay £6-7 for a pint in an average pub. As with restaurants, pubs close to major tourist attractions cash in on travellers' gullibility so be on your guard for the tourist traps where higher prices are not unheard of. If you're looking to save money and meet travellers then pub crawls are guided tours that run nightly in central London. You'll save the ticket price on the savings you get from discounted drink deals and what you would have spent on club entry. The "1 Big Night Out" pub crawl is the biggest operator and starts from near Leicester Square Tube station.



Pubs are everywhere in London

Many local pubs tend to be more reasonably priced with good drink promotions on weekday nights and during the day. A good place to get cheap ale beer is at any one of the Sam Smith pubs (<http://www.jamesgretton.co.uk/samuelsmiths/#/London>) found across Central London,

including Soho and the City. In the Bloomsbury area, check out **The Court** (near the north end of Tottenham Court Road) and **The Rocket** (Euston Road). Both are fairly cheap, given that they cater for students of the adjacent University College London. Directly opposite the British Library is **The Euston Flyer**, popular with locals and commuters alike given its close proximity to St Pancras International railway station.

Classier bars and pubs can be much more expensive. However, the cost of alcohol drops significantly the further away you go from the centre (West London tends to be an exception, with prices pretty much the same as the centre). For a more reasonably priced (but brilliant) cocktail bar than you'll find in the central and West End areas **Lost Society** in Clapham on Lavender Hill, cocktails here cost around £7-8 each.



The Viaduct Tavern bar interior



Two historic London breweries are Young's and Fullers. Young's was founded in Wandsworth in 1831 (but has relocated to Bedford) and nowadays it has 123 pubs in central London alone. **The Founder's Arms** next to the Tate Modern on the river embankment, is one of the brewery's most well-known establishments with a great view of the River Thames. Fullers was founded a bit later in 1845 at Chiswick (where you can take a most enjoyable tour of the brewery, including beer-tasting) and the jewel in its crown is probably the Grade I listed **Old Bank Of England** on Fleet Street, thanks to its breath-taking interiors. Fuller's flagship beer is the famous 'London Pride', however to try a truly authentic Cockney pint, ask at bars if they serve a seldom seen now **porter**, a dark style of beer originating in London in the 18th century, similar but less heavy than a **stout**. For a different taste, try a **gin and tonic**.

It's hard to say which pub in London is truly the oldest but it's easy to find contenders for the title. Many pubs were destroyed in the Great Fire of London – indeed, Samuel Pepys supposedly watched the disaster from the comfort of **the Anchor** in Borough. Pubs were rebuilt on sites that claimed to have been working pubs since the 13th century. **Ye Olde Cheshire Cheese** in Fleet Street is on the site of an old monastery and its cellar dates back to the 13th century. The **Princess Louise** and **Cittie of Yorke** are two lovely pubs close by along High Holborn with interesting decor; as is the **Jerusalem Tavern** of Farringdon, a converted Georgian coffee shop, which sells the Norfolk beer, St. Peters. **The Royal Oak** of Borough, is another pub which is the only representative of an out-of-town brewery in London, that of Harvey's of Lewes. The food is fantastic as is the atmosphere. Those interested in London's historic and literary connections can't miss **The Spaniard's Inn** in Hampstead. Dick Turpin is said to have been born here; John Keats and Charles Dickens both drank here; it's mentioned in Dickens' *The Pickwick Papers* and Bram Stoker's *Dracula*. The Goose at Catford, was reputedly a favourite hole of Karl Marx.

For the best view in the city, try pubs on the banks of the Thames. The South Bank has lots of good bars with views of iconic bridges and buildings. One lesser-known cocktail bar sits in the OXO Tower, which is a secret that most tourists walk by every day. Heading towards Bermondsey, pub crowds become a little less touristy. For something historic try the *Prospect of Whitby* in Wapping which has been on its site since 1520 and claims to be the world's oldest riverside tavern.

If you're after gastropubs, you may like to visit London's first, **The Eagle**, in Clerkenwell, established in 1991. You can also try *Time Out*'s favourite newcomer, **The Princess Victoria** on Uxbridge Road, Shepherd's Bush. The "Bermondsey Beer mile" is home to many craft breweries which are open in the middle of the day most Saturdays. Situated under the railway arches on lines going to London Bridge, these quaint breweries are home to high quality beer at cheap to average London prices (~£2 per half). Best places include Kernel Brewery and Brew by Numbers.

Wine buffs can enjoy the famous **Davys** wine bars that dot the city. The company, established in 1870, import wines and own over thirty bars in the centre. Other big names in wine include the Michelin-starred **Cellar Gascon** and **Vinoteca**, both in Smithfield. For a posh wine tasting experience, there is **Vinopolis** by Borough Market, though a tour price will be as eye-watering as the produce sampled. Big hotels, such as The Langham, The Dorchester and The Ritz, and upmarket clubs around Leicester Square and Soho are reliable bets for a date at the bar. The Connaught Hotel in Mayfair-Marylebone boasts its house bar, plus the *Time Out* magazine favourite, The Coburg. Still in Mayfair, The Polo Bar at The Westbury is very intimate.

You can rely on most up-and-running bars to offer a short cocktail menu and there are also bars that position themselves as cocktail specialists.

Nightclubs

Nightlife is an integral part of London life and there are countless nightclubs in and around Central London with music to suit even the most eclectic of tastes. Districts in London tend to specialize in different types of music.

The Farringdon/Hoxton/Shoreditch area has many clubs playing drum and bass, techno, house and trance music and is home to the superclub Fabric. The clubs in this area are often home to the world's top DJs and attract a lively, hip and friendly crowd. Big name drum and bass, house and techno DJs also appear at clubs scattered around Kings Cross (Egg, Scala), Elephant (Ministry of Sound, Corsica Studios), Southwark (Cable), Whitechapel (Rhythm Factory), or at mixed nights at the Vauxhall clubs. Nights are also hosted in disused Hackney warehouses or south London car parks.

The area around Mayfair is home to the more upmarket clubs in London. This area attracts a rather more showy crowd who love to flaunt what they have and is a must go to celebrity spot. Beware that drinks are ridiculously expensive and many clubs operate a guestlist-only policy. Music played here is often of the commercial chart, funky house, hip hop and R&B genre. Notable clubs include China White, Luxx, Maddox, Jalouse, Funky Buddha, Whisky Mist, Mahiki, No 5 Cavendish Square, Embassy, Vendome and Maya.

Nightclubs around the Leicester Square area hold the same music policy, but are rather more accessible, with numerous club and pub crawl promoters scattered around the area offering deals on entry. Notable clubs are Cafe De Paris, 1 Big Night Out pub crawl, Penthouse, Sound, Tiger Tiger, Zoo bar and Ruby Blue. The Camden area is home to clubs which play Indie, metal and rock music and notably the Electric Ballroom, the world-famous Koko (Fridays) and Underworld. Camden clubs are mostly shut (or empty) on the weekdays. In South London,

London's Afro-Caribbean centre Brixton is home to numerous venues with all kinds of music, including a particular presence in reggae, ska, afrobeat, hiphop, and dubstep. There are also venues in Peckham and New Cross.

Gay and lesbian

See also: LGBT London

London has a vibrant gay environment with countless bars, clubs and events in almost every district in the city.

The nucleus of London's gay scene is undoubtedly Old Compton St and the surrounding area in Soho but over the last couple of years Vauxhall has seen a boom in Gay venues. You will find that many areas, particularly in Camden Town and Shoreditch, that straight bars will have a mixed clientele. To find out what is going on during your visit, you can check:

- **qxmagazine.com (<http://qxmagazine.com>)**. A weekly magazine that comprehensively covers the London gay scene with handy night by night listings available on-line and in print
- **Boyz Magazine (<http://boyz.co.uk/>)**. Which is published fortnightly and is freely available at most London gay venues, and contains listings of everything that is happening in all the major clubs in London and the South East.

Gay Pride (<http://prideinlondon.org/>) is held every year in June with a parade and street parties. The choice of places to go sometimes seems to be unmanageable.

- **London Gay and Lesbian Switchboard (<http://llgs.org.uk>)** (LLGS), ☎ +44 20 7837-7324, admin@llgs.org.uk (<mailto:admin@llgs.org.uk>). This voluntary service has been operating since 1974 and as well as providing counselling they offer an incredibly thorough information service about Gay events, accommodation and businesses in London.

Sleep

London has hundreds of options for accommodation to suit all budgets from hostels through historic bed and breakfasts (B&Bs), mainstream chain hotels and apartments all the way to some of the most exclusive luxury hotels in the world such as The Savoy, The Ritz and Claridges where a stay in a top suite will cost upwards of £1,000 per night. The average cost of hotel accommodation in London is higher than in any other major British city. Prices invariably become inflated close to major sporting tournaments (such as the London Marathon, Wimbledon or major England football/rugby fixtures), or other important events taking place in the city - so it pays to plan your trip around such occasions or book your accommodation well in advance.

In general, most people tend to stay within "Zone 1" of the underground, however do your research carefully - sometimes being that extra five minutes away from a station can make the difference in cost and quality of local food and drinking options. In any case, you can always catch a bus anyway - by far the best way to see the city and get about generally. If you stay outside of Zone 1, TfL's travel time map (

reType=&selectedCompareValue=&travelTimeInterval=15&zoomLevel=13&places=&places=Travel+times&scenario=Base+Year&mode=All&timeOfDay=AM&direction=Average) shows which locations have good public transport.

Hotels

Your budget will have a lot to do with what part of London you will want to stay in. Expect smaller than average rooms especially at the low end of this range. Many of the big name chain hotels now offer substantial discounts if you book well in advance, but the drawback is that you have to pay the full amount upfront at the time of booking and there are no refunds if you cancel. The heart of the West End is the most expensive place to stay and most hotels are either four- or five-star and most will command a hefty price premium.



Hotel Russell on Russell Square



The City and Canary Wharf can also be very expensive during the week, as they rely heavily on the captive business market, but prices often drop dramatically over the weekend when the business travel dries up. Booking there can be a good way of getting into a higher standard of accommodation than you could otherwise afford. However, much of the City becomes a ghost town over the weekend, and you will find that few bars and restaurants are open away from the main tourist attractions.

Be exceptionally careful regarding the big "budget" hotel chains such as Premier Inn and Travelodge; prices for their London hotels (in contrast to elsewhere) can often meet or exceed those of other, better quality hotels, so it cannot just be assumed that you will get a good deal from them. Some of Travelodge's City of London hotels especially are of *shockingly* poor quality for the prices they charge.

A top tip, however, is to always check the likes of Expedia and LateRooms as well as the hotel's own website since there are often deals to be had which can reduce the costs significantly.

The extra cost of getting around is probably not significant compared to savings made by staying in a hotel further out near an Underground or railway station. Always be sure though to check where the closest Tube station is to your hotel. Staying further out will be cheaper but when travelling in allow 1-2 min per Tube stop (near the centre), around 2-3 min per stop (further out) and 5-10 min per line changes. This can easily total up to a 1 hour journey if there is a walk at each end. There are many hotels close to transport hub stations such as Stratford, Greenwich, Ealing Broadway, Wimbledon and East Croydon.

A more imaginative alternative could be to stay in a nearby town with quick and easy train travel to London. For example, lively Brighton (otherwise known as 'London by Sea') is only an hour away, but your budget will go much further and there are excellent accommodation options.

Some of the better value options are to be found in the following central districts:

- Bloomsbury. Relatively quiet district with a wide range of accommodation, and has enjoyed a surge in popularity following Eurostar's move to St Pancras International station. Cartwright Gardens features a dozen small B&Bs in historic houses. Many budget options are located

on Argyle Square (just off the Euston Road). Gets a little seedy towards and beyond King's Cross railway station.

- Earl's Court and West Kensington in west central London. Budget and modest accommodation as well as good 4-star hotels. Be careful with the cheapest accommodation in this area though as it will likely be very seedy indeed.
- Paddington and Bayswater in north west central London. Has undergone a lot of change largely resulting from the Heathrow Express train coming into Paddington station. Good hotels can be found in the immediate area of the station and in quieter spots a short walk away as well as in the traditional mid-range accommodation area further south in Bayswater.
- Westminster. Lots of small B&Bs around the back of Victoria railway station in the Pimlico area.

A slightly left-field option is to check the **Landmark Trust** (<http://www.landmarktrust.org.uk/>), a building preservation charity who purchase notable old buildings in the UK, renovate and run them as holiday lettings. An interesting approach to saving old buildings for sure.

Hostels

Not necessarily as unpleasant as you may think, and as long as you don't mind sharing with others, they are the most cost-effective option and also offer breakfast, and kitchens for self-catering.

There are independent hostels throughout the city which are listed in the relevant district articles.

In the summer season, many of the colleges and universities in Central London open up their **student halls of residence** as hotels during vacations, at usually much lower rates than proper hotels, but expect very basic facilities (e.g. communal bathrooms, no catering facilities), but you will get the personal privacy that you don't get in hostels for not very much more cost.

Apartments

Some apartment-hotels offer good value accommodation for those travelling in a group - often better quality than many hotels but at a cheaper individual rate per person.

Capsule-style crash spaces are just arriving, but they are only in central locations.

Short-term apartment or flat rentals are an attractive option for many travellers to London, and there are innumerable agencies offering them, almost all of them nowadays through the internet. A key consideration for renting a short term flat is if you are visiting in a large group or a family. In such cases a short stay in London can be more affordable compared to staying in a hotel. Your best protection is to deal only with London apartment rental agencies which have been recommended by independent sources you feel you can trust, and to deal only with those that accept confirmations via credit card.

An additional option in this sector is serviced apartments for stays longer than two weeks, the price being between £60 and £150. The apartments are a hybrid between hotels and apartments, including cleaning and desk services.

Alternative accommodation

Travellers can choose from a variety of homestay styles such as home-swapping (lovehomeswap.com), living in a temporarily vacated room (anyfriendofours.com) or the high end version where companies specialize in homestays with full hotel services such as housekeeping and concierge (viveunique.com). Most of the time these options are safe but it is important that guests and homeowners take equal precaution to ensure their valuables are safeguarded. Homeowners should always provide guests with terms and conditions of their live-in house rules to ensure there are no mishaps and both parties are at ease. This new trend allows guests to enjoy a less touristy version of London as most of these homes will be in residential areas which each have their own unique charm and experiences.

Holiday rentals

Hotels are generally expensive in London when compared with other European cities. As a result the city has a vast amount of self-catering accommodation on offer. Many of them are apartments in various central areas of the capital. Well established local sites include **Holidaylettings.co.uk** (<http://www.holidaylettings.co.uk/>), **Space Apart Hotel** (<http://www.spaceaparthotel.com/>), **Owners Direct** (<http://www.ownersdirect.co.uk/>), **stay.com** (<https://www.Stay.com>) and **Alpha Holiday Lettings** (<http://www.alphaholidaylettings.com>). If you are looking to stay in just a room or part of the property, **Airbnb** (<https://www.airbnb.co.uk>) matches holidaymakers with hosts who only rent out part of their homes.

Connect

Wi-Fi access

London is unfortunately not noted for free public wifi access - although the number of hotspots is continuing to grow.

- **O2 Free Hotspots** (<https://www.pocket-lint.com/news/46647/o2-provides-free-london-wifi>). O2 offers free wifi around London's busiest streets including parts of Oxford Street and Regent Street. Click on the link to see the map. Free.
- **Online-4-Free.com** (<http://online-4-free.com/>). One of the most promising (it seems) for traveller-frequented areas, a service that provides blanket coverage along the banks of the River Thames (and some surrounding streets) from Millbank down to Greenwich Pier, and a small "cloud" in Holborn - the free service asks only that you view a short advertisement every half hour to get 256 kbit/s (higher rates and ad-free come at a small charge). Free.
- **Tate Modern** (<http://tate.org.uk/modern/>). Offering free wifi for a trial period.
- **British Library** (<http://bl.uk/>). Offers free internet access throughout the library with registration.
- **Royal Festival Hall at Southbank Centre** (<http://www.southbankcentre.co.uk>). Offers free unencrypted wifi throughout the building without registration.
- **Apple Store Regent St (Tube: Oxford Circus)**. The Apple Store on Regent Street offers free wifi and has a theatre at the back of the first floor where you can sit and spend an hour or two.
- **London Underground** (<http://my.virginmedia.com/wifi/index.html>). Virgin Media offers wifi access at Tube stations. Some mobile phone networks offer free access, otherwise you

have to pay.

- Free wifi is also available in many cafes, and the following chain outlets: McDonald's, Pret A Manger, JD Wetherspoon pubs, Costa Coffee, Caffe Nero, Starbucks.

Stay safe

In an emergency, telephone **999** or **112**. This number connects to police, ambulance and fire & rescue services as well as the coastguard for incidents on the river. You will be asked which of these services you require before being connected to the relevant operator.

London has two of the oldest police forces in the world. The Metropolitan Police (<https://www.met.police.uk/>) (*The Met*) is responsible for policing London except the tiny City of London, which is the responsibility of the City of London Police (<https://www.cityoflondon.police.uk/>). In addition to these, the Tube and other railways are patrolled by the British Transport Police (<https://www.btp.police.uk/>).

On the whole, London is a safe place to visit and explore. Normal precautions for the safe keeping of your personal possessions, as you would in any other city, are suggested.

Crime

Like many big cities, London has a variety of social problems, especially begging, drug abuse and theft; mobile phones are a favourite target, often snatched by fast-moving moped riders. Make sure you have security and anti-theft features enabled on your phone as thieves are getting more sophisticated and will try to access your personal data and banking apps.

The police have placed significant resources in combating street level crime. Working in conjunction with borough councils and the City of London Corporation, they have brought the level of theft and pickpocketing in major retail areas in London to a manageable level. Pickpocketing in London is not as rampant as in other major European cities, though it still pays to be vigilant and take the usual precautions in securing your valuables.

Street gang culture is a growing problem in London as with many other cities in England. While most groups of youngsters are not likely to present any danger to tourists, some people feel the need to be slightly more vigilant in certain areas, especially certain outer suburbs. Violent crime is in general not common, but most typically occurs between members of rival gangs, rather than on random members of the public.

Main precautions to take

- **Keep valuables out of sight.** Many crimes are opportunistic - a lot of mobile phones are snatched from restaurant tables. By keeping items such as cash and mobile phones out of



A Traditional 'Blue Lamp' outside a police station in London

sight theft can easily be prevented. Don't flash your cash unnecessarily!

- **Keep bags zipped up and close to your body.** If your bag is hanging open it's like putting up a flashing neon sign saying "Steal from me!" Use zips and inside pockets to secure items wherever possible. Never leave valuables such as mobile phones, wallets, or travel documents in an outside section of your bag.
- **Be aware of your surroundings.** Before using your mobile phone have a look around you. Put your back against something solid such as a wall or window so you can't be approached from behind. If you're in a train or Tube station try to use your phone before leaving as all stations have CCTV. Constantly look around you, especially if you are in a busy area. **Don't walk and talk/text!**

Late at night

If you're planning to go out late at night and are worried about safety then try to frequent crowded areas such as the West End. There are always plenty of people on the street, even at 4AM. Generally, outside central London, the south, and east suburban areas are considered more dangerous, notably Brixton, Peckham and Hackney, although some parts of north-west London such as Harlesden and northern Camden are also known trouble spots.

The main problem throughout London to various degrees is drunken behaviour, particularly on Friday and Saturday nights and after football matches. Loud and rowdy behaviour is to be expected and fights and acts of aggression also occur. If you are harassed, it is best to simply ignore and walk away from those concerned. Trouble spots can be expected around popular drinking locations such as Soho and in various suburban centres.

Scams and cons

London has a large number of con artists around, all trying to convince you to hand over your money one way or another. In general, you should *never* give cash or your bank/credit card detail to people on the street no matter how genuine they seem.

Cash machine/ATM scams: Most usage of these machines is perfectly safe, but there are various ways that thieves can either obtain your card or your cash when using an ATM. It is always safest to withdraw cash using a machine inside a bank, but street machines are usually more convenient. Before inserting your card visually check the machine for anything that looks odd. Thieves sometimes install cameras above the pin pad. If things look OK then reach out and wiggle the slot where you insert your card - if the slot's loose, don't put your card in, as there may be a device installed to trap your card. All good? OK, is there anyone standing too close to you or hovering nearby? If so, perhaps cancel the transaction and go elsewhere. If everything's good then go ahead! When obtaining your cash and retrieving your card hover your hand over the slot to be ready to grab them as soon as they come out. Is anyone trying to distract you? Don't let them and leave swiftly. If you notice anything odd about a cash machine or people nearby then phone the police on 101 (999 in an emergency) or report it to the premises the machine is attached to. Don't try to remove any devices yourself.

Cup and ball game: This variant of a scam dating back into antiquity is perhaps the most common and is frequently seen on the busier pedestrian bridges such as Westminster Bridge. A person will lay out a mat with three cups on it. They will pretend to hide a ball under one of the cups, move the cups around, and then ask you to place a bet on where the ball-containing cup has landed. There is no ball - the con artist will have spirited it away! This con always has people

acting as lookouts in the crowd and they will pretend to win every now and again so it looks like the game is winnable. Also beware if you are just stopping to watch as you could be pick-pocketed!

Overzealous street performers: Most street performers are happy to just do their thing, let you watch, and then you can throw them a few coins if you liked the show. However, some street performers will actively grab and harass passers-by in order to get attention and money. They may forcefully pose with you and ask you to take a photograph and then demand money for the photo opportunity. They may also take this opportunity while you're distracted to pick-pocket you. Don't engage with any street performer who is pushy or forceful - try to walk away, or call out "Get off me!" or "No!" and draw attention to yourself if you can't escape easily.

Tissue sellers on trains: Beggars will get onto a train and place tissues on the seats with a note begging for money. They want you to feel pity for them and buy the tissues, but this is an organised scam and the money goes towards criminal enterprises. If you see this happening on a train don't buy the tissues and ignore anyone who asks you for money for them. If you're above ground you can text the British Transport Police on 61016 (http://www.btp.police.uk/61016_text_service1.aspx) to report it.

"Clip joint": Soho presents a particular danger: the "clip joint". The usual targets of these establishments are lone male tourists. Usually, an attractive woman will casually befriend the victim and recommend a local bar or even a club that has a "show". The establishment will be near-desolate, and, even if the victim has only a drink or two, the bill will run to hundreds of pounds. If payment is not immediately provided, the bouncers will lock the "patrons" inside and take it by force or take them to an ATM and stand over them while they extract the cash. To be safe, if a woman you just met suggests you go to a specific place, try to recommend a different bar. If she insists on hers then walk away and do not listen to her suggestions. Sometimes this con trick takes place when someone is lured into a private club with the promise of something perhaps more than a drink (like a "private show" or sex for a small amount of money). A "hostess fee" will appear on the bill for several hundred pounds, even though there has been nothing more than polite conversation.

"Stress tests": If anyone offers you a free "stress test", they are likely trying to recruit you into the Church of Scientology. The best option is to walk away as people are commonly harassed into giving personal details.

Needing money for phone/train tickets/the bus/et al.: Someone will approach you asking for money for public transport. They will claim that they have lost their Travelcard or that it has been damaged somehow. Occasionally a person with a very convincing fake injury will ask for money so that they can get a taxi to hospital, strangely refusing the offer of you calling an ambulance or the police for them as you would do for most injured people in the street. Ignore them.

Ticket machine scam: One of the most popular scams in London is the ticket machine scam: While buying a ticket at a train station someone will approach you and act as if they want to help you buy the right ticket. In reality, they will wait until your money is in the machine, then lean across, cancel the transaction and pocket your cash. Say "No thanks" politely - you know what ticket you want to buy!

Selling/asking for a donation for "lucky heather": This scam, usually operated by women, involves someone handing you "lucky heather" (a small flower usually wrapped in foil) and then either trying to sell it to you or asking for a monetary donation. They will come up with a vague charity ("money for sick children", "money for orphaned babies", and so on) and show you a purse full of supposed "donations". If you are handed one of these flowers either hand it back or drop it on the ground and leave. If you take the flower and leave without "donating" you could be chased and harassed by the people involved in the scam. In some of the poorer boroughs like Brixton, you may find alleged "Tibetan monks" scamming you into donating, which may be in fact to fund a local criminal gang or enterprise.

Pedicabs: A common sight in central London is a brightly lit rickshaw blaring loud music and offering rides. They are not regulated and often seriously overcharge their passengers.

Street collections

Although not illegal, London is a known hotspot for charity collectors, some of whom can be extremely persuasive in trying to obtain a donation; therefore they have earned the name "charity muggers" or "chuggers". If you do not want to donate, be polite but forceful, and under no circumstances provide any form of bank details. Some of these collectors are genuine scammers and are not collecting on behalf of any charity - larger charities ask their collectors to have specific and verifiable identification, and have card machines.

Transport

Don't take illegal minicabs (see Get around for details). No minicabs are allowed to ply for trade on the street, and any doing this should be avoided.

Travelling on the lower deck of a night bus is generally safer, as there are more passengers around, and you are visible to the bus driver.

If you've lost an item on the Underground, Overground or Docklands Light Railway, in a licensed black cab, or on a red London bus then you should contact the [TfL Lost Property Office \(https://tfl.gov.uk/help-and-contact/lost-property\)](https://tfl.gov.uk/help-and-contact/lost-property) as soon as possible. If an item is lost or misplaced on other transport services in London, the relevant service operator should be contacted.

Bank, credit and debit cards, when found, are securely destroyed. Contact your bank immediately if you lose these on a transport service.

On the London Underground, there is a scheme operated by the TfL aimed to stop crime: If you see or hear anything suspicious then: See it, Say it, Stop it.

Stay healthy

The UK's **National Health Service** (NHS) will provide *emergency* treatment for anyone in the UK, irrespective of whether they reside in the UK, but if you are not a UK resident you will be expected to make a contribution (up to the entire cost) towards such treatment. Travel insurance is essential. You can find NHS services near you [here \(https://www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/services-near-you/\)](https://www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/services-near-you/).

Emergencies

For a *life-threatening* medical emergency (unconsciousness, stroke, heart attack, severe bleeding that won't stop, etc.) dial **999** or **112** and ask for an ambulance. These numbers are free of charge from any telephone. When you call, the operator will ask for details about the patients and your location; answering these questions will not delay help. As emergency response is prioritised in London the operator needs to know what resources they need to use and how quickly you need them.

London's ambulance coverage is excellent. For instances of major trauma there is also **London's Air Ambulance** (<https://www.londonsairambulance.org.uk/>), two helicopters that can deliver an advanced trauma team within minutes to anywhere in London during daytime.

Emergencies can also be dealt with at most NHS hospitals with an **A & E** (Accident & Emergency) department. In A & E, be prepared to wait for a long time (although the target is 4 hours, waits can be longer than this) before being given treatment if your medical complaint is not critical. For less serious problems, try an Urgent Care Centre (<https://www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/urgent-and-emergency-care-services/find-urgent-and-emergency-care-services/>), or a high-street pharmacist.

Major hospitals

Major A & E hospitals in London are:

- **Charing Cross Hospital**, Fulham Palace Rd, Hammersmith, W6 8RF
- **Chelsea & Westminster Hospital**, 369 Fulham Rd, Chelsea, SW10 9TR
- **St George's Hospital**, Blackshaw Road, Tooting, SW17 0QT
- **Homerton University Hospital**, Homerton Row, Homerton, E9 6SR
- **King's College Hospital**, Denmark Hill, SE5 9RS
- **University Lewisham Hospital**, High St, SE13 6LH
- **Queen Elizabeth Hospital**, Stadium Road, Woolwich, SE18 4QH
- **Royal Free Hospital**, 23 East Heath Rd, Hampstead, NW3 1DU
- **The Royal London Hospital**, Whitechapel, E1 1BB
- **St Marys NHS Trust**, Praed St, Paddington, W2 1NY
- **St Thomas' Hospital**, Lambeth Palace Rd, South Bank, SE1 7EH
- **University College London Hospitals NHS Trust**, 25 Grafton Way, Bloomsbury, WC1E 6DB
- **Whittington Hospital**, Highgate Hill, Archway, N19 5NF

General medical advice

For advice on non-emergency medical problems, you can ring the 24 hour NHS Direct service on 111.

Treatment for non-emergency conditions, or for hospital admissions resulting from emergencies, is normally free for people holding a European Health Insurance card (EHIC) issued by most European governments, or certain other countries listed here (http://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/+www.dh.gov.uk/en/Healthcare/Entitlementsandcharges/OverseasVisitors/Browsable/DH_074379). In the absence of such a card you would be well advised to get private travel health insurance.

At large organised events, and in many theatre productions, basic medical assistance and first aid is provided through the support of organisations such as St John Ambulance or the stewards for the event.

Pharmacies

Pharmacies (often referred to as "chemists") are found across London (<http://www.nhs.uk/Service-Search/Pharmacy/LocationSearch/10>), with chains such as **Lloyds Pharmacy** and **Boots** being prevalent. Many independent pharmacies also exist. Most large supermarkets also have pharmacy counters, although these do not stock some of the stronger remedies. Unlike other European countries pharmacies in the UK are not often marked by prominent neon "green cross" signs.

Pharmacists are also able to offer advice on many health problems and recommend medicines that might help. For certain remedies (for example stronger painkillers) you may have to ask at the counter, as for regulatory reasons these can only be sold by pharmacists under strict protocols. Don't be alarmed if the pharmacist asks some basic diagnostic questions or for your ID.

Cope

Finding a toilet

Need to spend a penny? Some businesses allow people to use their facilities without purchasing anything, others reserve them for customers only. **The Great British Public Toilet Map** (<https://www.toiletmap.org.uk/>) attempts to map publicly-accessible toilets and baby changing facilities.

All the main London rail terminals now have free toilets, although cleanliness can vary. Transport for London have produced a **map of stations on their network with a toilet** (<https://content.tfl.gov.uk/toilets-map.pdf>). Where a pictogram is white and outlined, this indicates that lavatories are outside the gateline (thus open to all), while black filled-in mark toilets which are inside the gateline so only accessible to passengers or those willing to pay to touch in and out. Finally, the presence of an asterisk tells you whether a fee is charged for use of the facilities.

For fact fans: the Central line has the most stations with toilets, at 29, and the Piccadilly line is close behind with 28. However, the sheer length of these lines and the number of stations skew the figures. Therefore, the lines with the greatest proportion of stations with loos and thus those lines which are best for regular customers are the Metropolitan line with 27 toilets out of a total of 34 stations (or 79% coverage), and the Jubilee line with 21 comfort areas across 27 stations (77%). As a shuttle between two of the busiest stations on the network, the Waterloo and City line naturally hits 100% loo coverage, and with its name you'd be disappointed if it didn't. By contrast, passengers should be prepared to cross their legs on the Docklands Light Railway, as across a network of 45 stations, a paltry 6 have toilets.

Embassies and High Commissions

London is a good place to get visas, being home to the fourth largest number of diplomatic missions in the world. Some embassies have a separate consular section for issuing visas, passports, notary services, etc., found in a different location from the chancery. It is advised to check their website or call them ahead of time if you need these services. The major English-speaking countries' embassies are marked on the dynamic map at the top of the article; to locate them, click the green number next to their flag.

Diplomatic missions	list [Expand]
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Go next

- [Nerd activities in London](#)

England

Day-trips

- [Aylesbury](#) – Historic market town.
- [Berkhamsted](#) – Historic market town. Features the ruined castle of William the Conqueror, canal-side pubs, and Ashridge Forest.
- [Bournemouth](#) – Large beach resort on the edge of the [New Forest](#), with seven miles of golden sand.
- [Brighton](#) – Fashionable beach town that is arguably Europe's gay capital.
- [Canterbury](#) – Site of the foremost cathedral in England, constructed during the 12th-15th centuries.
- [Eastbourne](#) – A leafy seaside resort town of Victorian architecture, with a lovely pier and bandstand. Famous for [Beachy Head](#) chalk cliffs, and a popular viewing platform.
- [Hastings](#) – Picturesque seaside town famous for the battle of 1066, where small fishing boats are launched directly from the beach.
- [Hemel Hempstead](#) – A small town dating back to the 8th century, home to the UK's largest indoor ski slope.
- [Henley-on-Thames](#) – A quaint and typical English town on the river, great for walks, rowing and sailing. Home to the famous boating Regatta in summer.
- [Lewes](#) – Delightful mid-Sussex town, with a picturesque brewery and the famous Guy Fawkes festival in November.
- [Maidstone](#) – County town of [Kent](#), known as the Garden of England.
- [Margate](#), [Broadstairs](#), and [Ramsgate](#) – A trio of seaside resorts of the Isle of Thanet in [Kent](#).
- [Rochester](#) – A favourite town of Charles Dickens with loads of history in the form of a medieval cathedral and castle. Nearby [Chatham](#) has a strong naval heritage.
- [Portsmouth](#) – Home of the Royal Navy and of real interest to nautical enthusiasts. Also offers access to the [Isle of Wight](#).
- [Southend-on-Sea](#) – An [Essex](#) seaside town with pebble and sand beaches, fairground rides, arcades, and the longest pier in the world. Make sure to grab yourself a delicious Rossi ice cream – a local delicacy since 1932.
- [Shaftesbury](#) – A small, beautiful [Dorset](#) town, one of the oldest in Britain.

- St Albans – Small, quaint cathedral city with Roman heritage; home to Verulamium Museum and Verulamium Park.
- Stonehenge – Among the most famous landmarks in England. The mysterious stone ring was built thousands of years ago, today it is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Best visited in combination with a trip to nearby city Salisbury, where you can also visit the 13th-century cathedral with the highest spire in the country.
- Winchester – Former capital of England and attractive cathedral city with lots to see.
- Windsor and Eton – Nearby Thames-side towns with magnificent royal castle, its extensive estate, and one of Britain's most prestigious private schools.

Further afield

- Bath – Well-heeled spa city with ancient Roman bathhouse and spectacular Georgian and Regency architecture.
- Birmingham – Boasts many events, pubs and clubs, and shopping opportunities.
- Cambridge – Gothic university colleges and chapels, and punting on the river.
- Manchester – The second most visited city in England.
- Oxford – The "city of dreaming spires", with dozens of fascinating university colleges and museums to visit.
- Shrewsbury – A very traditional town full of medieval black and white timber-framed buildings along winding, steep, narrow streets set on the River Severn.
- The South Downs National Park – Beautiful, rolling chalk hills for a day's stroll or longer hikes.

Abroad

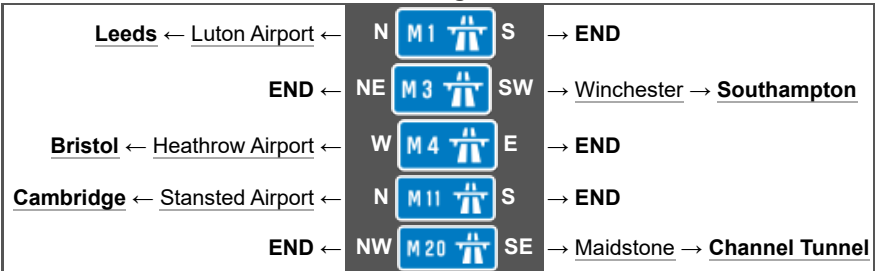
Eurostar high-speed trains from St Pancras station make the following continental cities tempting next stops from the British capital:

- Lille – 1 hr 20 min to northern France's post-industrial gem.
- Brussels – 2 hr to the home of Tintin, moules-frites, and the European Union.
- Paris – 2 hr 15 min to the city of Notre-Dame, the Louvre and the Eiffel Tower.
- Disneyland Paris – 2 hr 40 min to the Magic Kingdom, with a change of trains in Lille.
- Rotterdam – 3 hr to the Netherlands' modern, multicultural commercial centre.
- Amsterdam – 3 hr 40 min to the Dutch capital's canals, museums and red light district.

Routes via London



Routes through London



END ←	N	M 23	S	→ Gatwick Airport → Brighton
Birmingham ← High Wycombe ←	NW	M 40	SE	→ END

Routes through London

Peterborough ← Potters Bar ←	N	A1	S	→ END
END ←	NW	A2	SE	→ Gravesend → Dover
END ←	NE	A3	SW	→ Guildford → Portsmouth
Reading ← Heathrow Airport ←	W	A4	E	→ END
St Albans ← Watford ←	NW	A5	SE	→ END
Cambridge ← Hertford ←	N	A10	S	→ END
Chelmsford ← Brentwood ←	NE	A12	SW	→ END
Aylesbury ← Watford ←	NW	A41	SE	→ END

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